User Manual

UNZA Hostel Maintenance Request and Tracking System

University of Zambia — Final Year Project

User Manual

UNZA Hostel Maintenance — report, track and resolve hostel maintenance issues.

This manual explains how to use the system, step by step, for each kind of user. Jump to your section:

- 1. Getting started (everyone)
- 2. Students
- 3. Technicians
- 4. Administrators
- 5. Settings, notifications and dark mode
- 6. Working offline
- 7. Meanings of statuses, priorities and badges
- 8. Frequently asked questions

> The screenshots use sample data.

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1. Getting started (everyone)

What you need

A phone, tablet or computer with a web browser and an internet connection. No download from an app store is required.

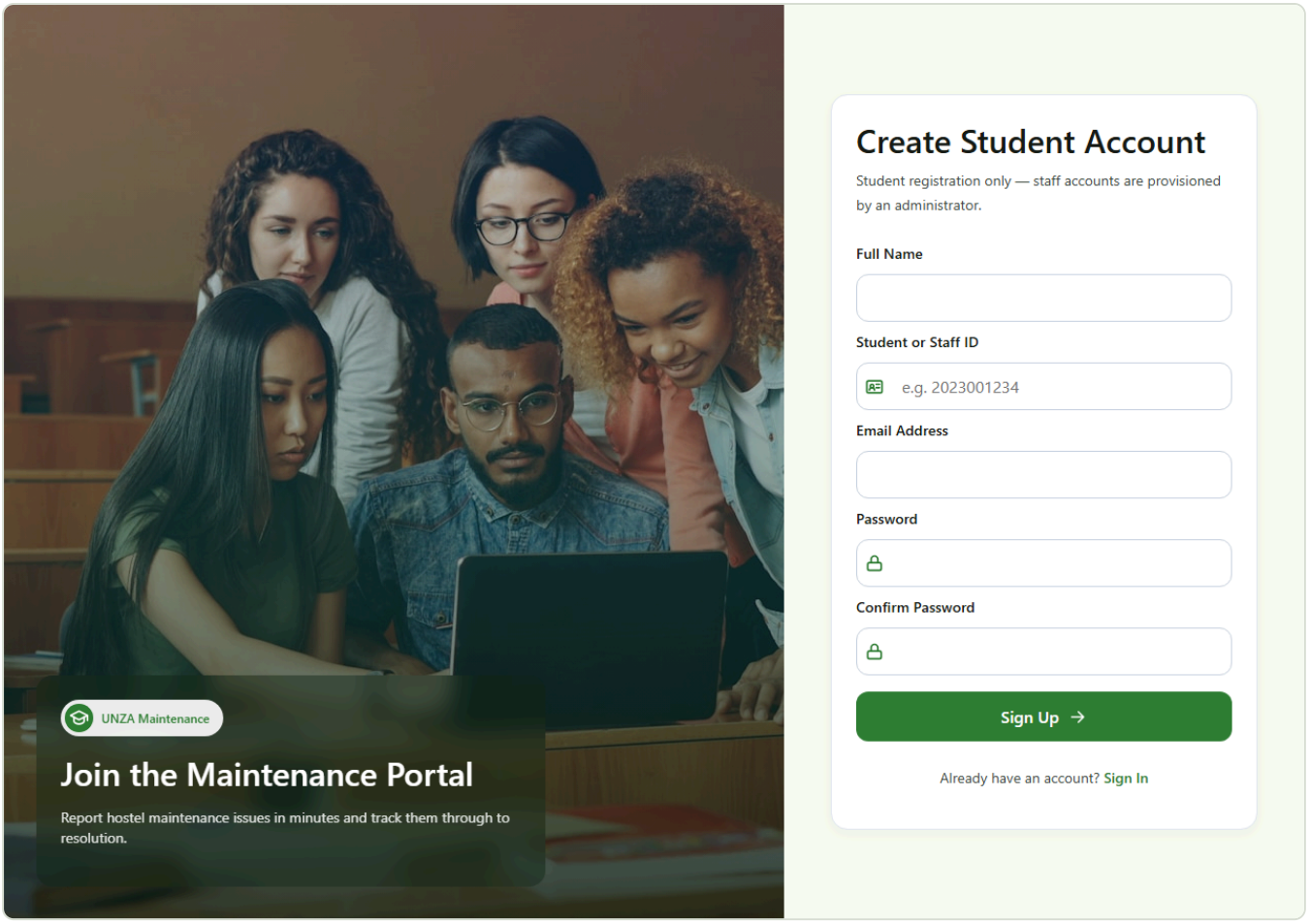
Roles

Role	What you can do
Student	Report faults, back faults others have reported, track your own requests, rate repairs
Technician	See the jobs assigned to you, update their progress, add proof of the finished work
Administrator	See every request, assign technicians, manage staff accounts, view reports

Creating an account (students only)

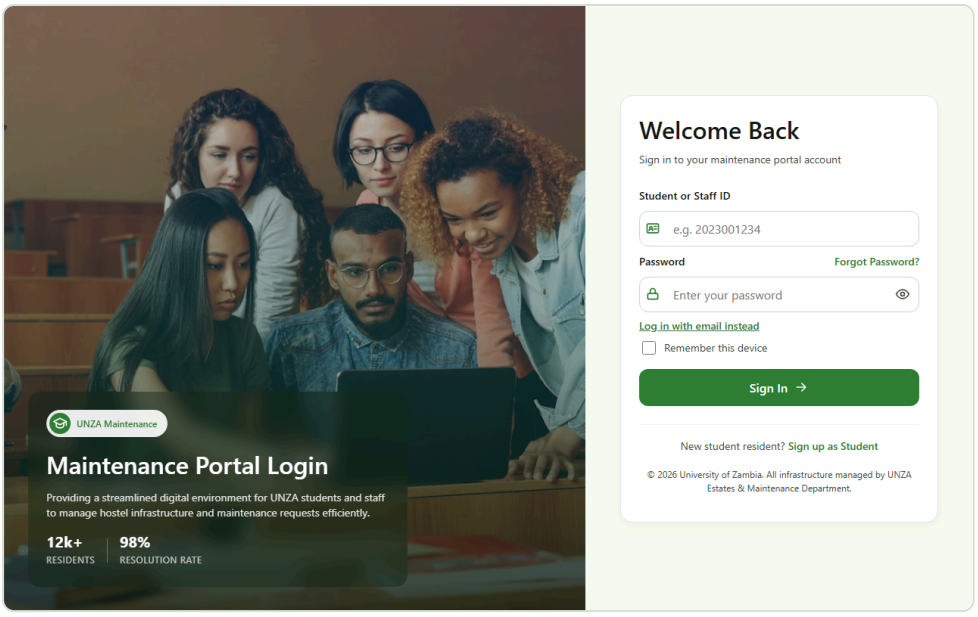
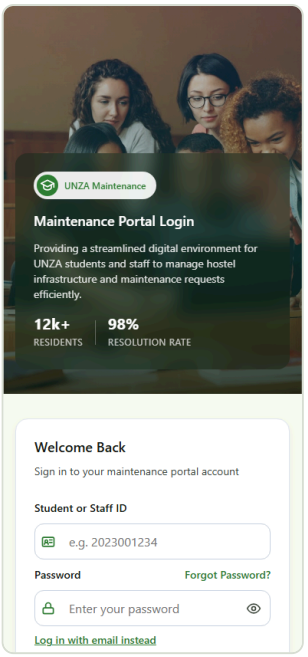
Students register themselves; technician and administrator accounts are created for you by an administrator.

1. Open the website and choose **Sign up as Student** under the sign-in form.
2. Enter your **full name**, **student ID**, **email address** and a **password** (at least 8 characters).
3. Submit. You can now sign in.



Signing in

1. Enter your **Student or Staff ID** and your password, then press **Sign In**.
2. Prefer email? Choose **Log in with email instead**.
3. Tick **Remember this device** on your own phone or laptop so you stay signed in. Leave it unticked on a shared computer.

Computer	Phone
	

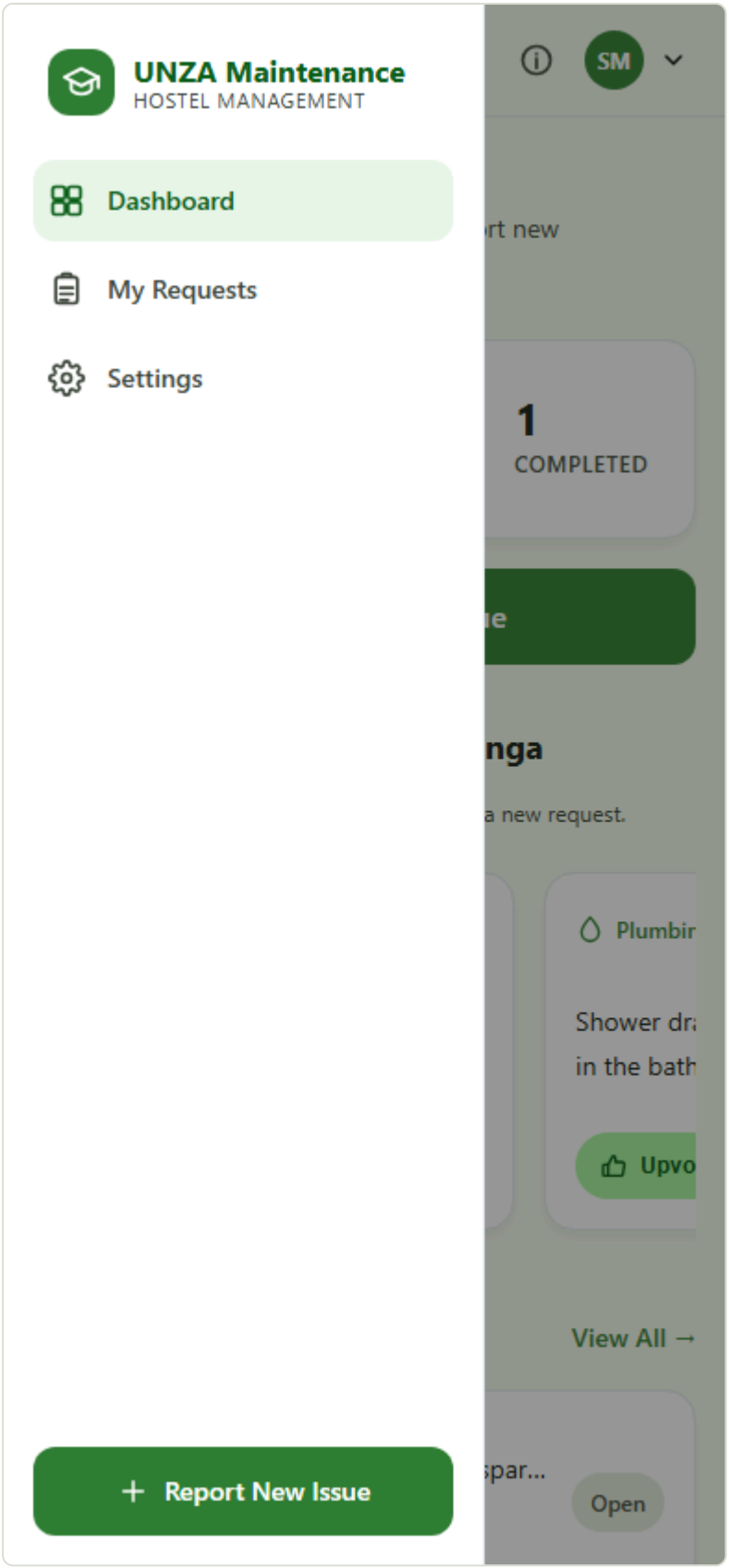
Installing the app on your phone (recommended)

The site is a *Progressive Web App*: you can add it to your Home Screen so it opens like a normal app, loads faster and can send you notifications.

- **Android (Chrome):** open the site → menu (⋮) → **Install app** / **Add to Home screen**.
- **iPhone (Safari):** open the site → **Share** button → **Add to Home Screen**. (On iPhone, notifications only work after you do this.)

Finding your way around

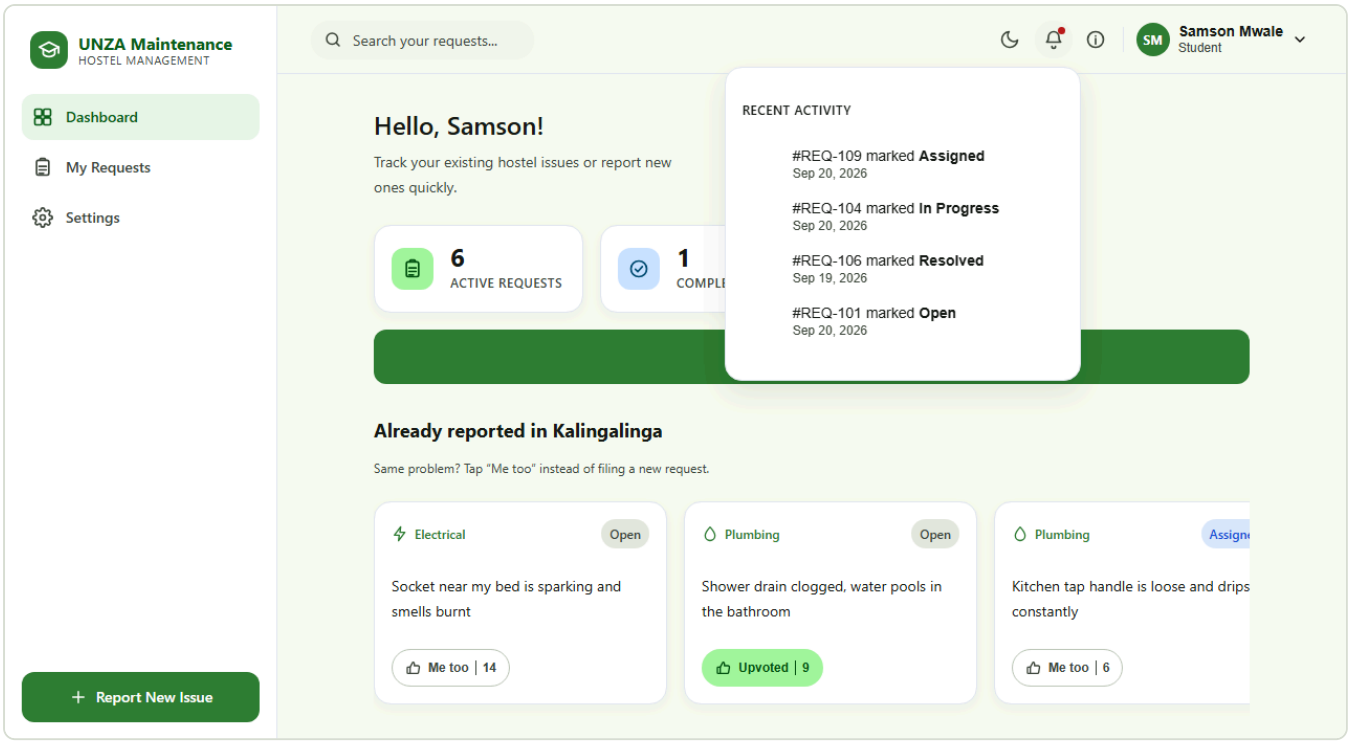
- **Computer:** the menu is on the left; the top bar has search, dark-mode toggle, notifications, help and your profile.
- **Phone:** tap the ☰ button (top left) to open the menu.



The top bar

Icon	What it does
🌙 / 🌞	Switch between dark and light mode
🔔	Recent activity (a red dot means there is something new)

Icon	What it does
ⓘ	Help — a short guide to what each status means
Your name	Profile and sign out

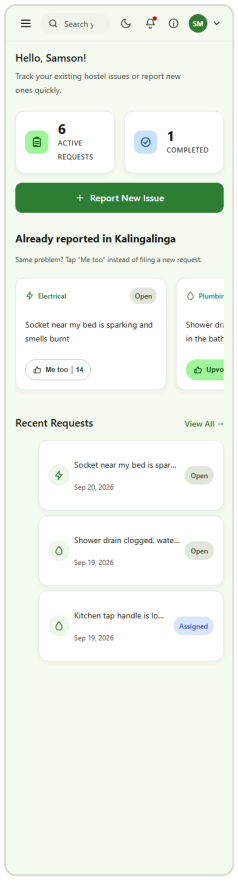
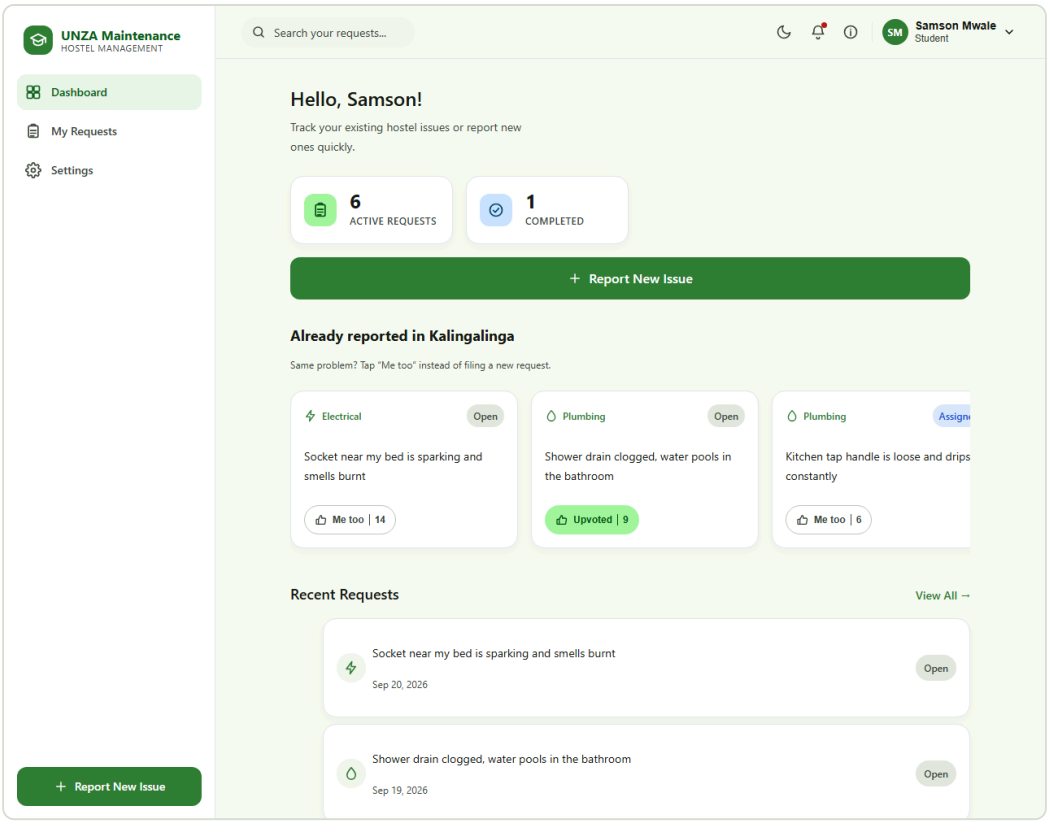


2. Students

2.1 Your dashboard

After signing in you see:

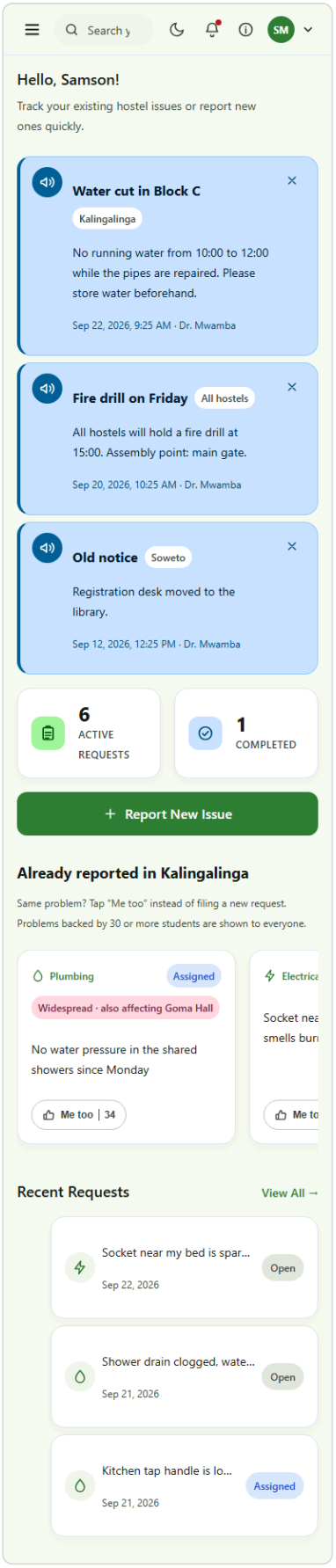
- **Announcements** — notices from administrators for your hostel, or for everyone (see 2.1a).
- **Active Requests** and **Completed** — how many of your requests are still being worked on or finished.
- **Report New Issue** — the big green button.
- **Already reported in your hostel** — issues other students have already reported (see 2.3).
- **Recent Requests** — your latest requests with their status.

Phone	Computer
	

2.1a Announcements

Notices from administrators appear at the top of your dashboard — either for **your hostel** only, or for **all hostels**. Each one shows who posted it and when.

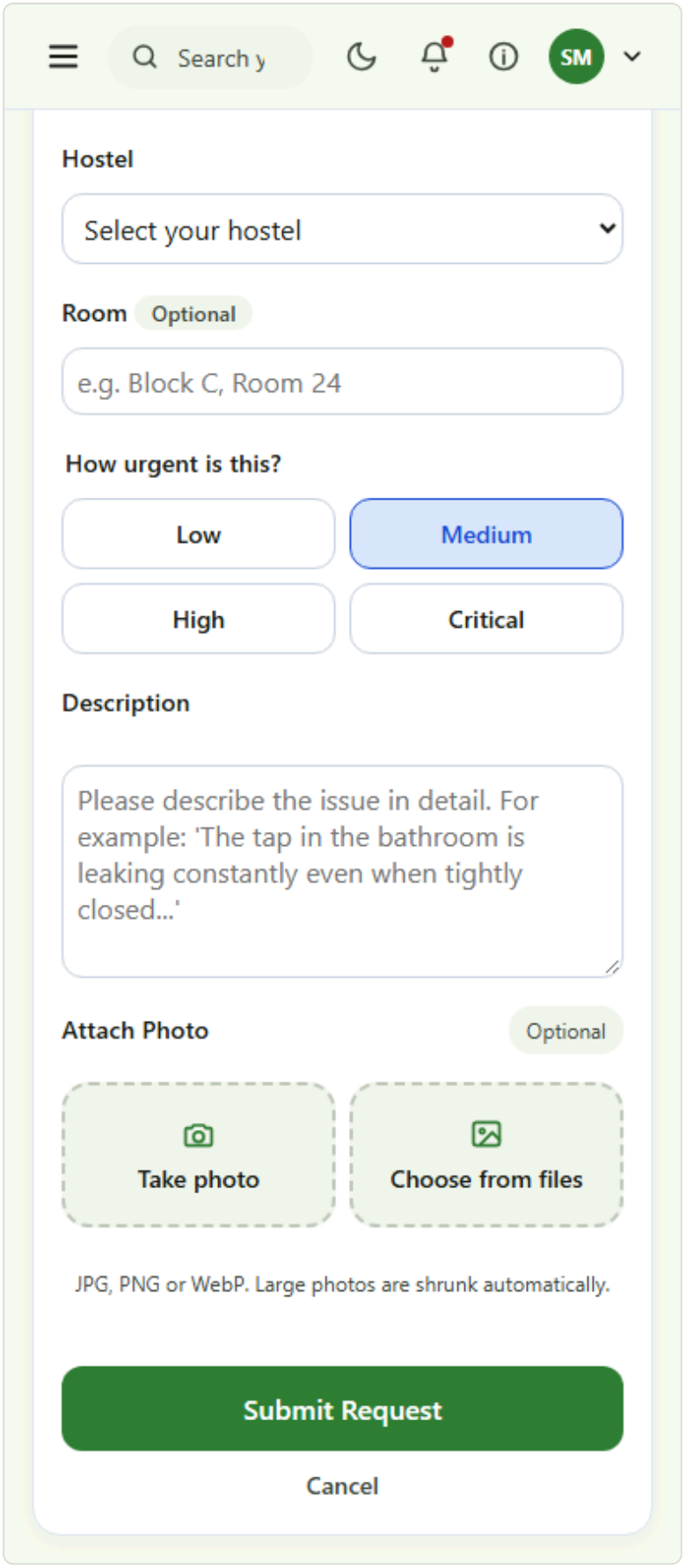
- Tap ✕ to dismiss a notice you have read. It will not show again on this device.
- You also get a **push notification** for a new announcement, if you turned notifications on (see section 5).
- Which notices you see depends on your **hostel** — set it once in Settings (see 5) so you get the right ones.

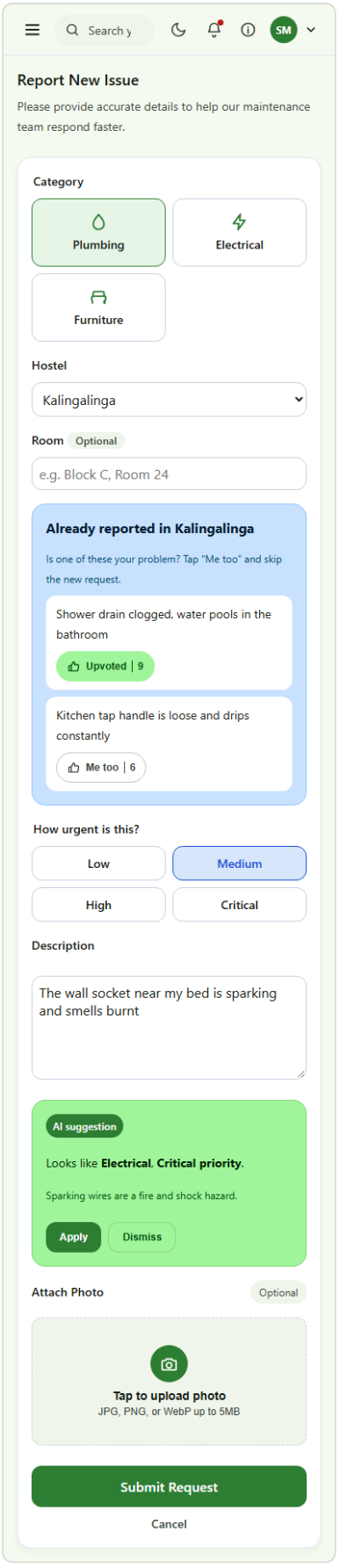


2.2 Report a new issue

1. Press **Report New Issue**.
2. **Choose a category** (Plumbing, Electrical, Furniture ...).

3. **Select your hostel** and, if you like, type your **room**.
4. **Say how urgent it is** — Low, Medium, High or Critical (see section 7).
5. **Describe the problem.** Be specific: "*The tap in the bathroom leaks even when tightly closed.*"
6. *(Optional)* **Attach a photo** — press **Take photo** to use your camera (on a computer, a live preview opens so you can capture one), or **Choose from files** to pick an existing picture (JPG, PNG or WebP, up to 5 MB). Large photos are shrunk automatically so they upload quickly.
7. Press **Submit Request**.


Search y
SM
Hostel
Select your hostel
Room
Optional
e.g. Block C, Room 24
How urgent is this?
Low
Medium
High
Critical
Description
Please describe the issue in detail. For example: 'The tap in the bathroom is leaking constantly even when tightly closed...'
Attach Photo
Optional
Take photo
Choose from files
JPG, PNG or WebP. Large photos are shrunk automatically.
Submit Request
Cancel



Two helpers appear while you fill the form:

- **"Already reported in your hostel"** — after you pick a category and hostel, if someone has already reported the same kind of problem you will see it here. If it is *your* problem too, tap **Me too** instead of filing a new request. You help the maintenance team see how many people are affected.

- **A suggestion** — as you describe the problem, the system may suggest a category and urgency ("Looks like Electrical, Critical priority"). Tap **Apply** to accept it or **Dismiss** to ignore it. **You are always in control** — nothing changes unless you tap Apply. Dangerous problems (fire, sparking wires, flooding, burst pipes) are always suggested as *Critical*.

> **No internet?** You can still write the request. It is saved on your device and sent automatically when you are back online (see section 6).

2.3 Back a problem someone else already reported ("Me too")

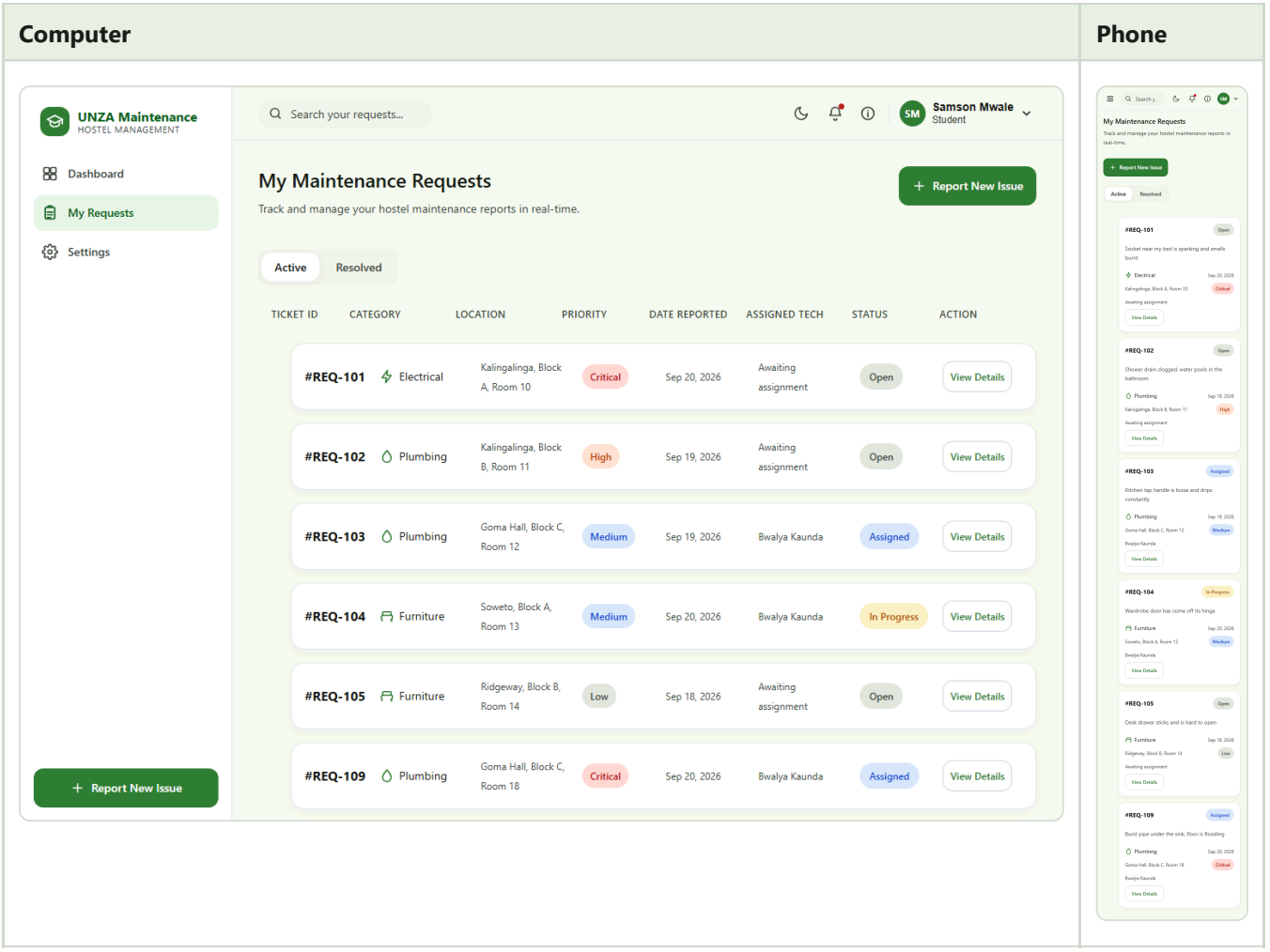
On your dashboard, swipe through **Already reported in <your hostel>**. Each card shows the category, a short description and its status.

- Tap **Me too** if you have the same problem. The button turns green and shows **Upvoted**.
- Tap it again to take your vote back.
- You cannot vote on your own requests, or on ones that are already resolved.
- Other students' names are never shown.
- **Widespread problems (30 or more "Me too" votes)** are shown to students in **every** hostel, not just where it was reported — labelled **"Widespread · also affecting <hostel>"**. A fault that big is probably a campus-wide issue (e.g. water pressure), so everyone affected can back it.

2.4 Track your requests

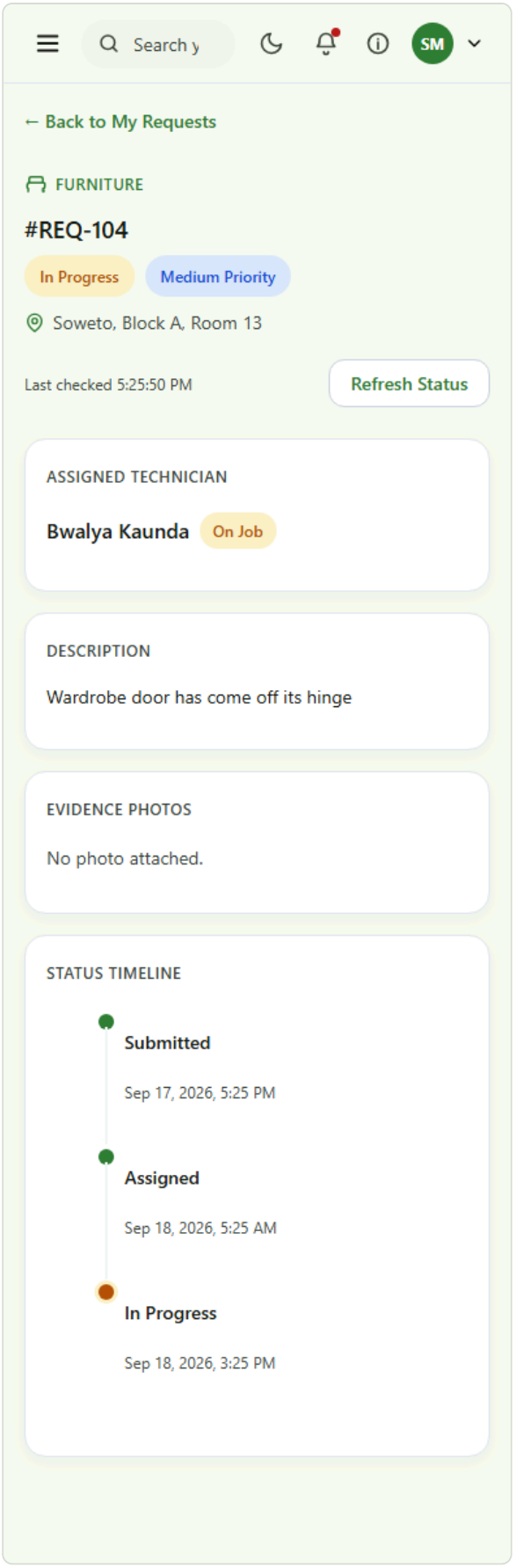
Open **My Requests** in the menu. Use the tabs to switch between active and finished requests, or the search box in the top bar to find one.

Computer | **Phone**

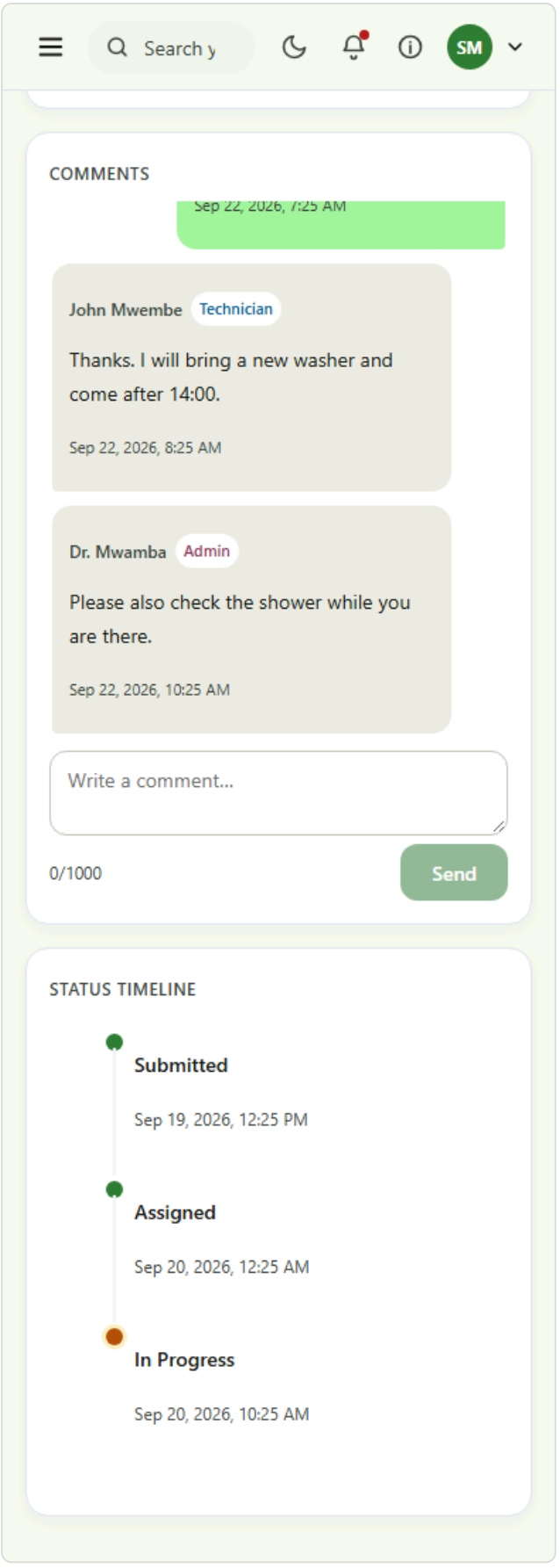


Tap any request to see its full page:

- the **status** and **priority**,
- who is **assigned** to fix it,
- a **Comments** box to talk with the technician and administrators about your request (e.g. "Which tap is it?"),
- a **timeline** showing every step with dates,
- for finished jobs, a **Work Completed** section with the technician's photo and note.



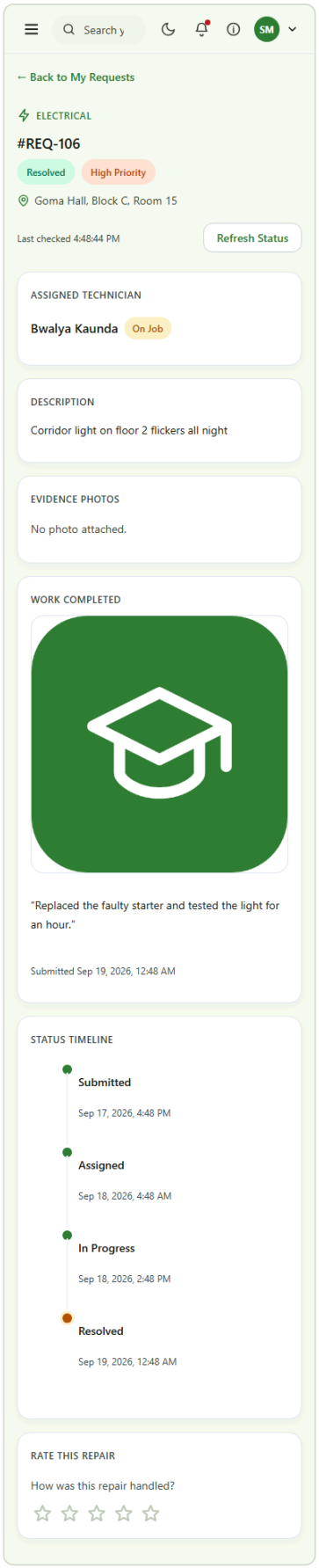
Comments — type your message and press **Send** (or Ctrl+Enter). Only you, the technician assigned to your request, and administrators can see or post comments on it — nobody else. Everyone involved gets a notification when someone new comments. Comments are turned off once a request is Closed.



The page updates by itself when something changes — you do not need to refresh. You can also press **Refresh Status**.

2.5 Rate a finished repair

When a request is **Resolved** or **Closed**, the request page shows **Rate this repair**. Tap 1–5 stars (5 is best) and, if you wish, add a comment. You can rate each request once.

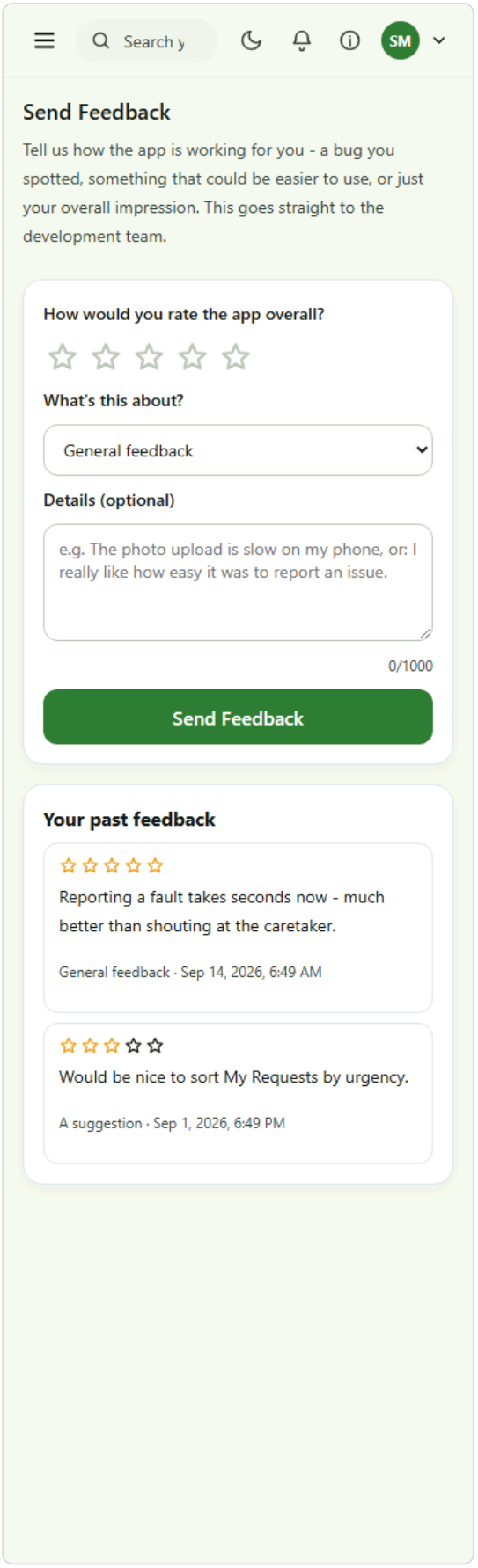


2.6 Give feedback about the app

Rating a repair (2.5) is about one technician's work on one request. If instead you want to say something about the **app itself** — a bug, a suggestion, or just how it's working for you overall — open **Feedback** in the menu. This is different from anything else in the system: it is the one channel that goes straight to the people building the app, for a student who does not otherwise have a direct line to them the way an administrator does.

1. Tap a **star rating** (1–5) for the app overall.
2. Choose what it's about — **General feedback**, **A suggestion**, or **Something is broken**.
3. *(Optional)* Add details.
4. Press **Send Feedback**.

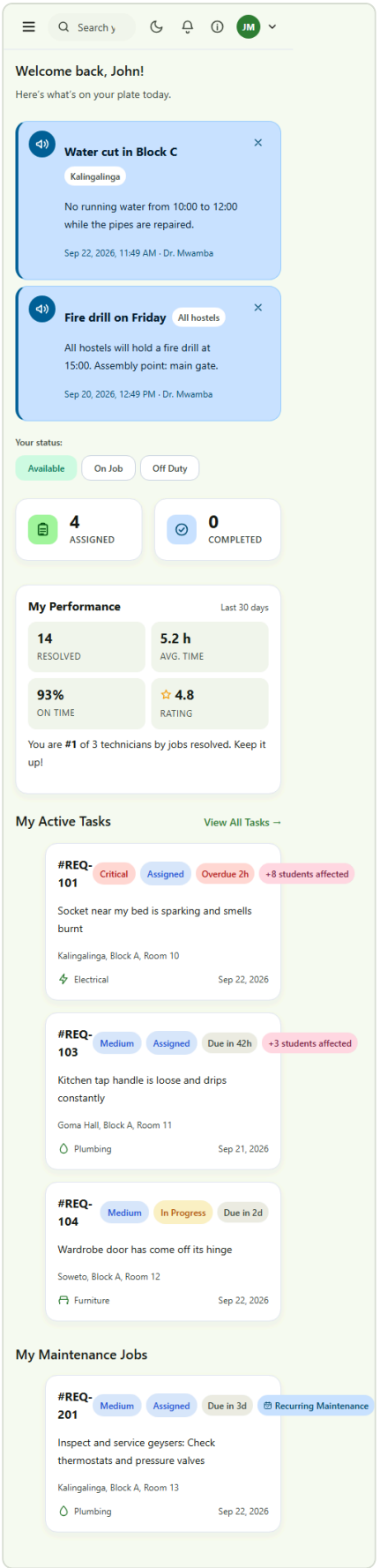
Your past feedback is listed below the form so you can see what you've already sent.


Search y
SM
Send Feedback
Tell us how the app is working for you - a bug you spotted, something that could be easier to use, or just your overall impression. This goes straight to the development team.
How would you rate the app overall?
What's this about?
General feedback
Details (optional)
e.g. The photo upload is slow on my phone, or: I really like how easy it was to report an issue.
0/1000
Send Feedback
Your past feedback
Reporting a fault takes seconds now - much better than shouting at the caretaker.
General feedback · Sep 14, 2026, 6:49 AM
Would be nice to sort My Requests by urgency.
A suggestion · Sep 1, 2026, 6:49 PM

3. Technicians

3.1 Your dashboard

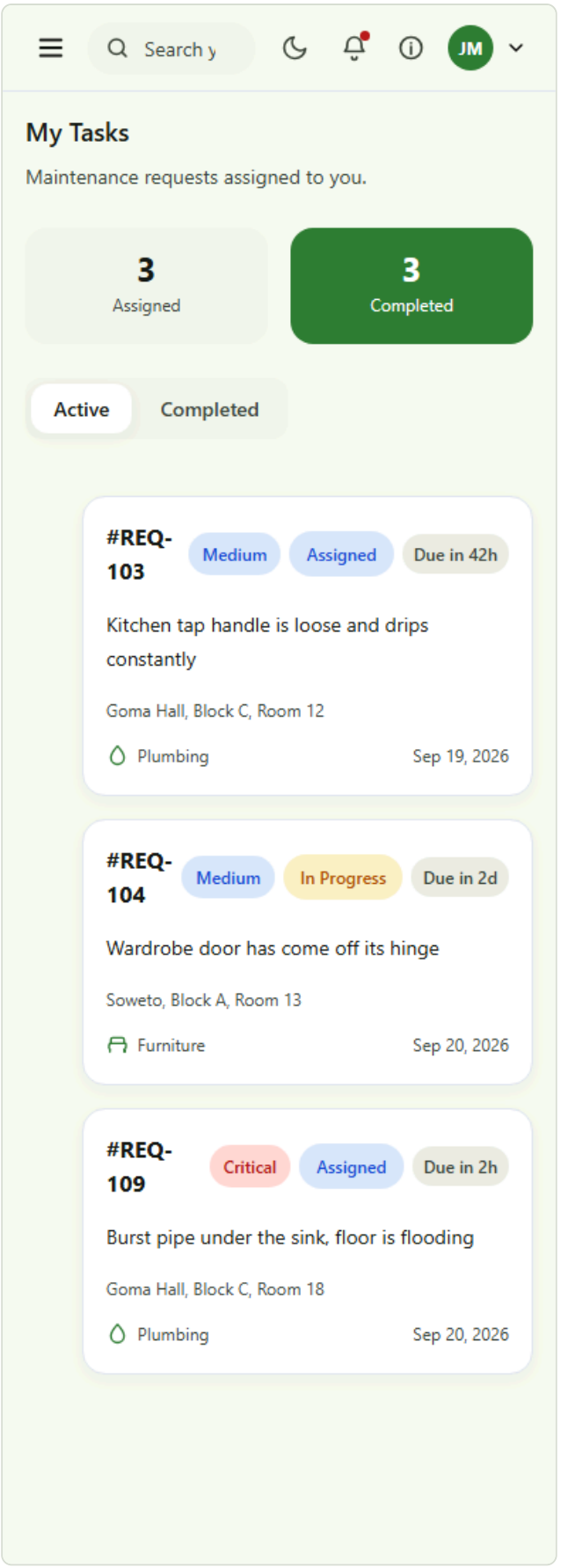
- **Announcements** from administrators appear at the top, the same as on a student's dashboard (2.1a) — you see every active notice, whatever hostel it targets, since your next job could be anywhere.
- Choose your **status** at the top — **Available**, **On Job** or **Off Duty**. Administrators use this when deciding who to assign, so keep it accurate.
- See how many jobs are **Assigned** to you and how many you have **Completed**.
- **My Performance** — your scorecard for the last 30 days: jobs resolved, average time, your on-time rate, and your rating from students. It also shows your rank among your colleagues, and warns you if any of your jobs are overdue.
- **My Active Tasks** lists faults students have reported to you, with their priority and a deadline badge.
- **My Maintenance Jobs** lists your scheduled preventive-maintenance checks separately (see 4.7) — kept apart from student-reported faults so you can tell at a glance which is which.



3.2 See your tasks

Open **My Tasks**. Each card shows the request number, priority, status, a deadline badge (for example *Due in 42h* or *Overdue 3h*), a **"+N students affected"** badge when several students backed the same issue with

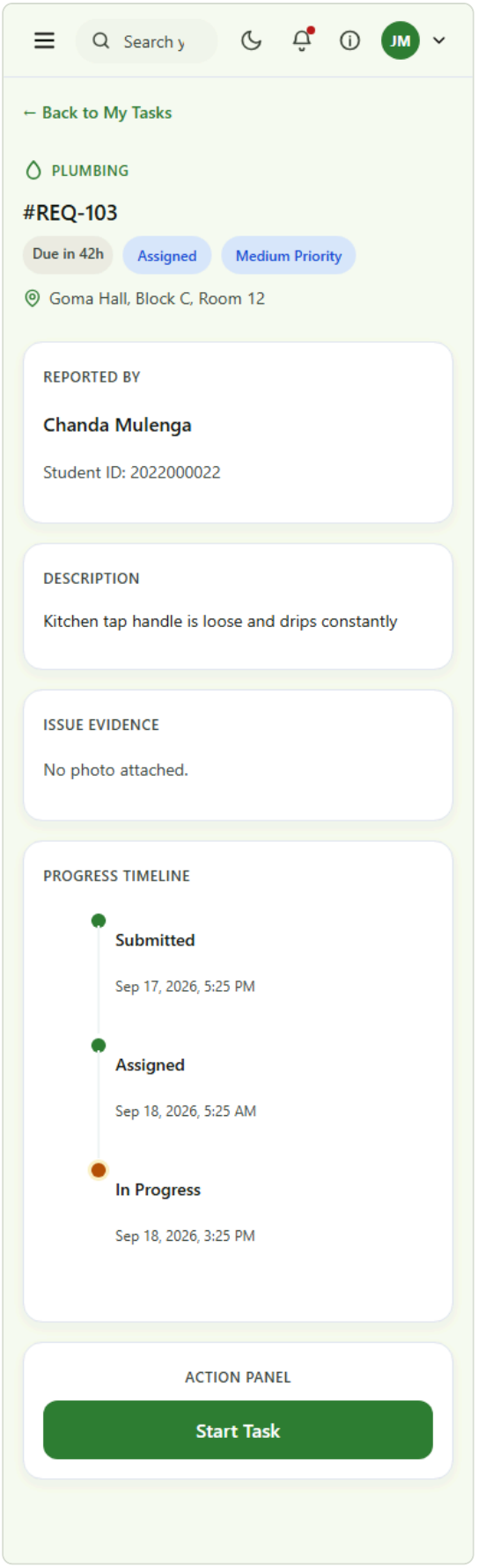
"Me too" (see 2.3) — tackle those first — the description and the location. A task that came from a preventive-maintenance schedule rather than a student report carries a **"Recurring Maintenance"** badge, on this list, the dashboard and the task's own page — opening it shows "Maintenance Schedule" instead of a reporting student, since nobody personally filed it.



3.3 Work on a task

Tap a task to open it. You will see who reported it, the description, the student's photo (if any), and the timeline.

1. When you begin, press **Start Task**. The status changes to *In Progress* and the student is notified.
2. When the repair is done, complete the **Action Panel** (below) and press **Mark as Resolved**.

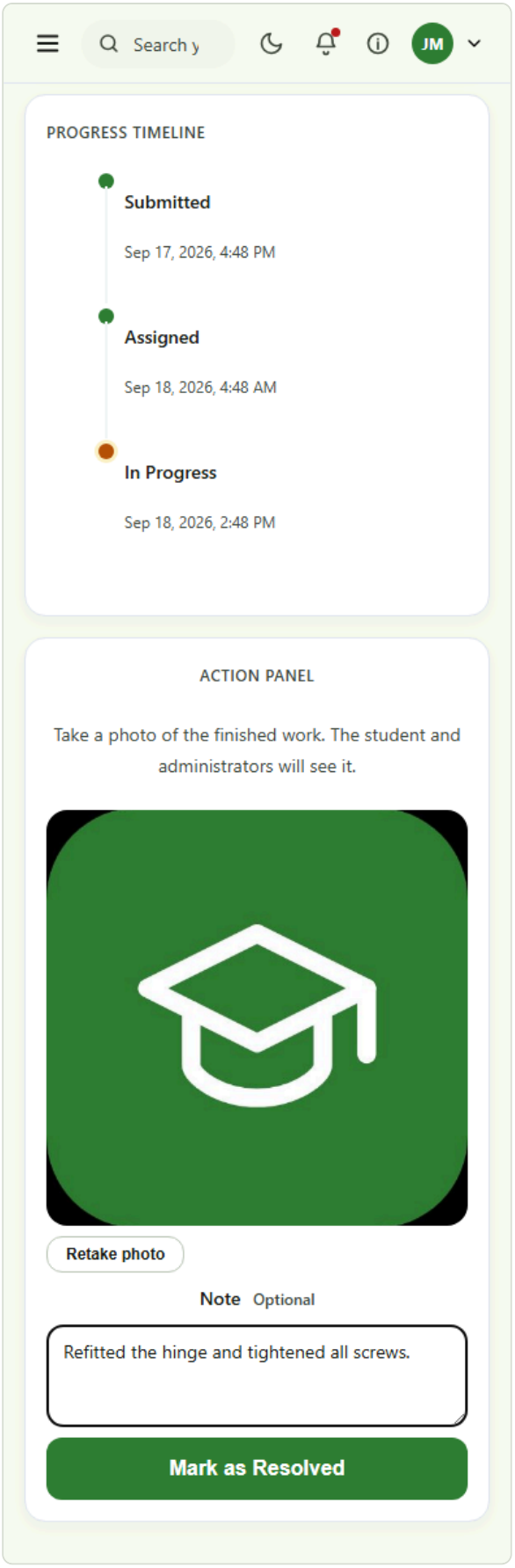


3.4 Add proof of the finished work (optional)

When you resolve a task you can:

- **Add a photo** of the finished repair — press **Take photo** (your camera opens on a phone; a live preview opens on a computer) or **Choose from files**. Use **Retake photo** if needed.
- **Add a note** (up to 500 characters), e.g. "*Replaced the washer and tested for leaks.*"
- You can also **Comment** on the task to ask the student or administrators a question (see 2.4).

The student and the administrators will see this under **Work Completed**. Photos are automatically reduced in size so they upload quickly on mobile data.



> You can only update tasks that are **assigned to you**.

3.5 Give feedback about the app

Same as for students (2.6): open **Feedback** in the menu to send a star rating, a category (general / suggestion / bug) and an optional comment about the app itself — not about one job. It's the way to reach the development team directly.

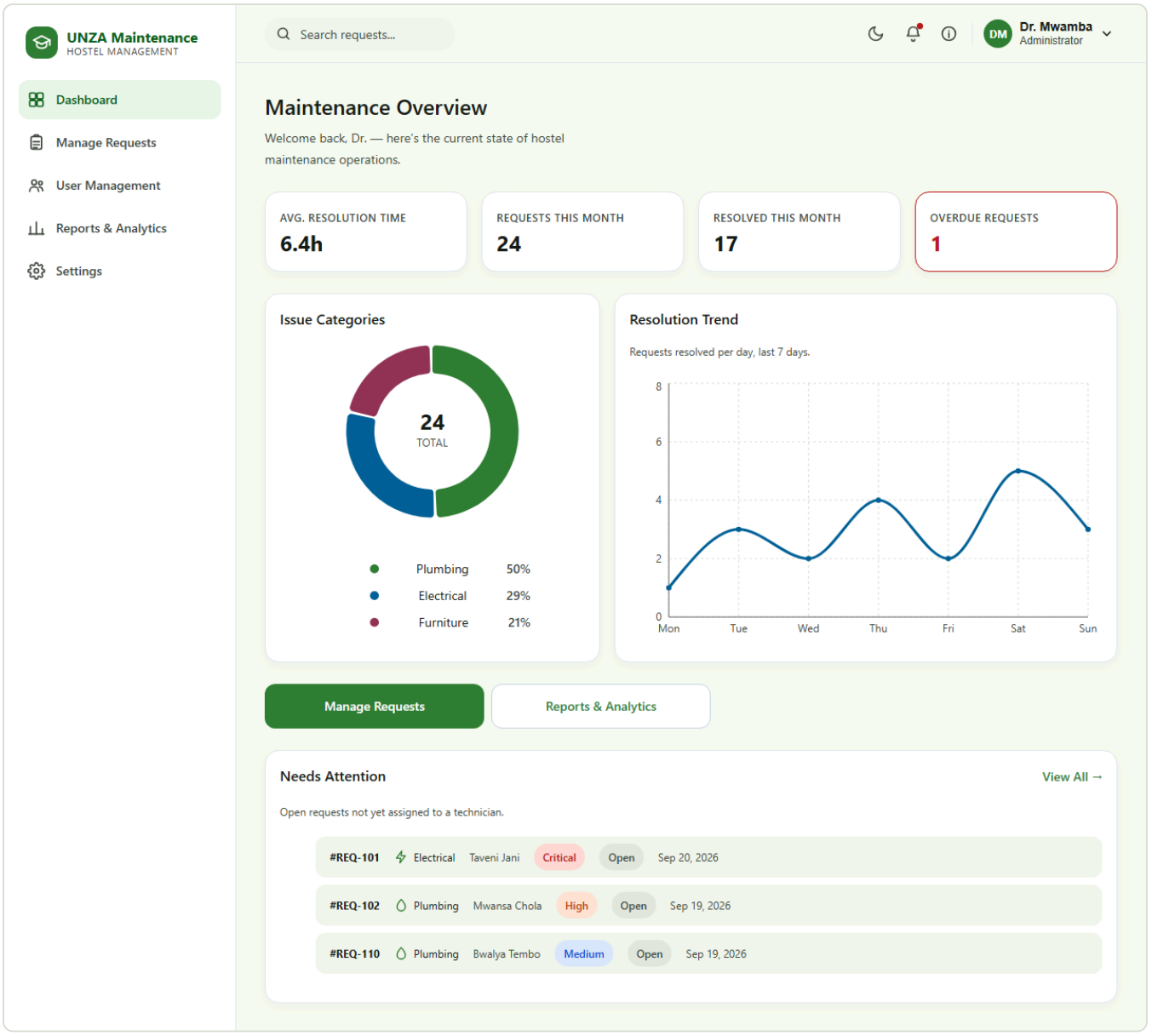
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4. Administrators

4.1 Dashboard

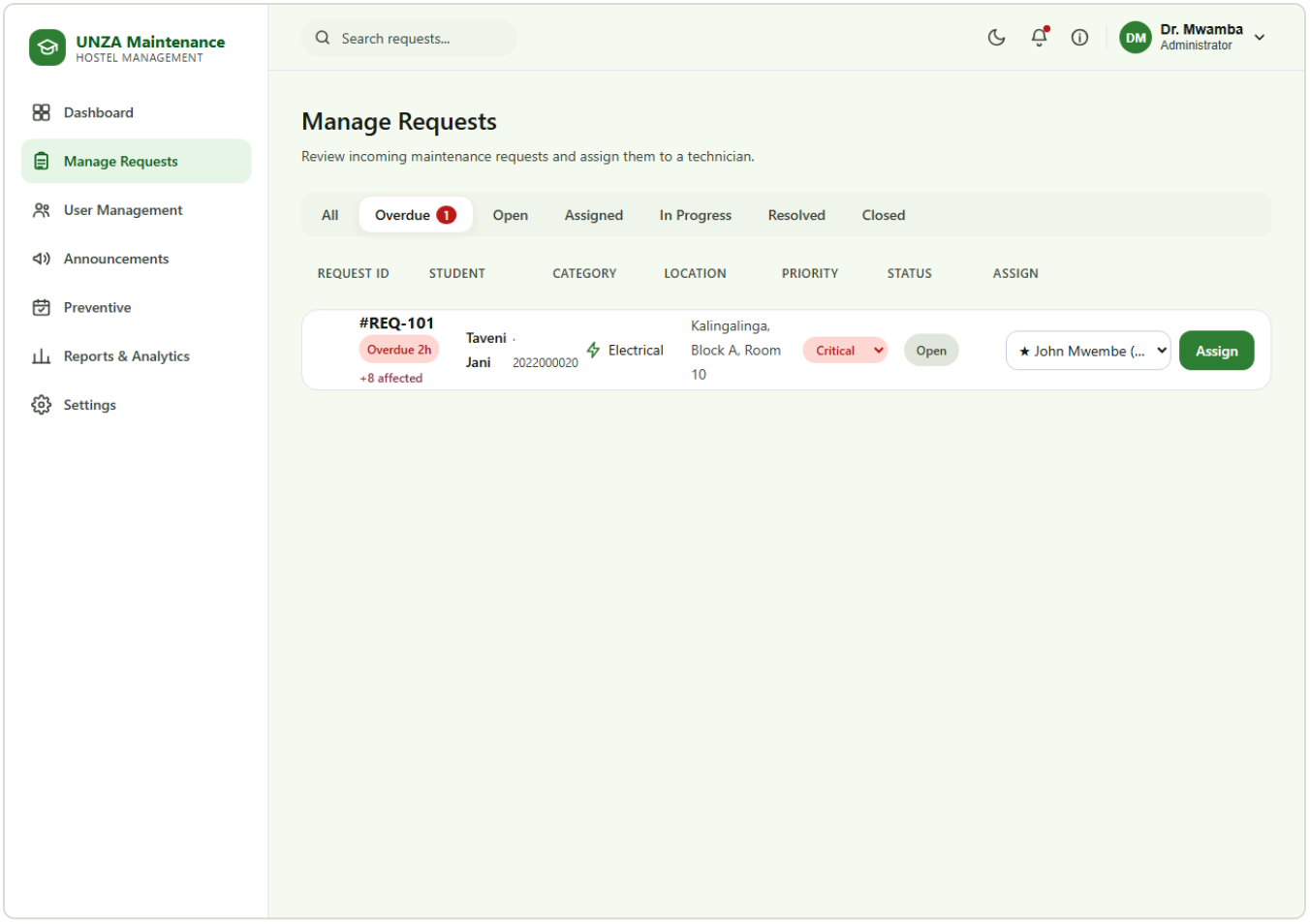
A quick health check of maintenance operations:

- **Avg. Resolution Time**, **Requests This Month**, **Resolved This Month**.
- **Overdue Requests** — turns red when any request has passed its target time. Tap it to go to the list.
- **Issue Categories** ring and **Resolution Trend** chart.
- **Needs Attention** — open requests not yet assigned, most urgent first.



4.2 Manage requests and assign a technician

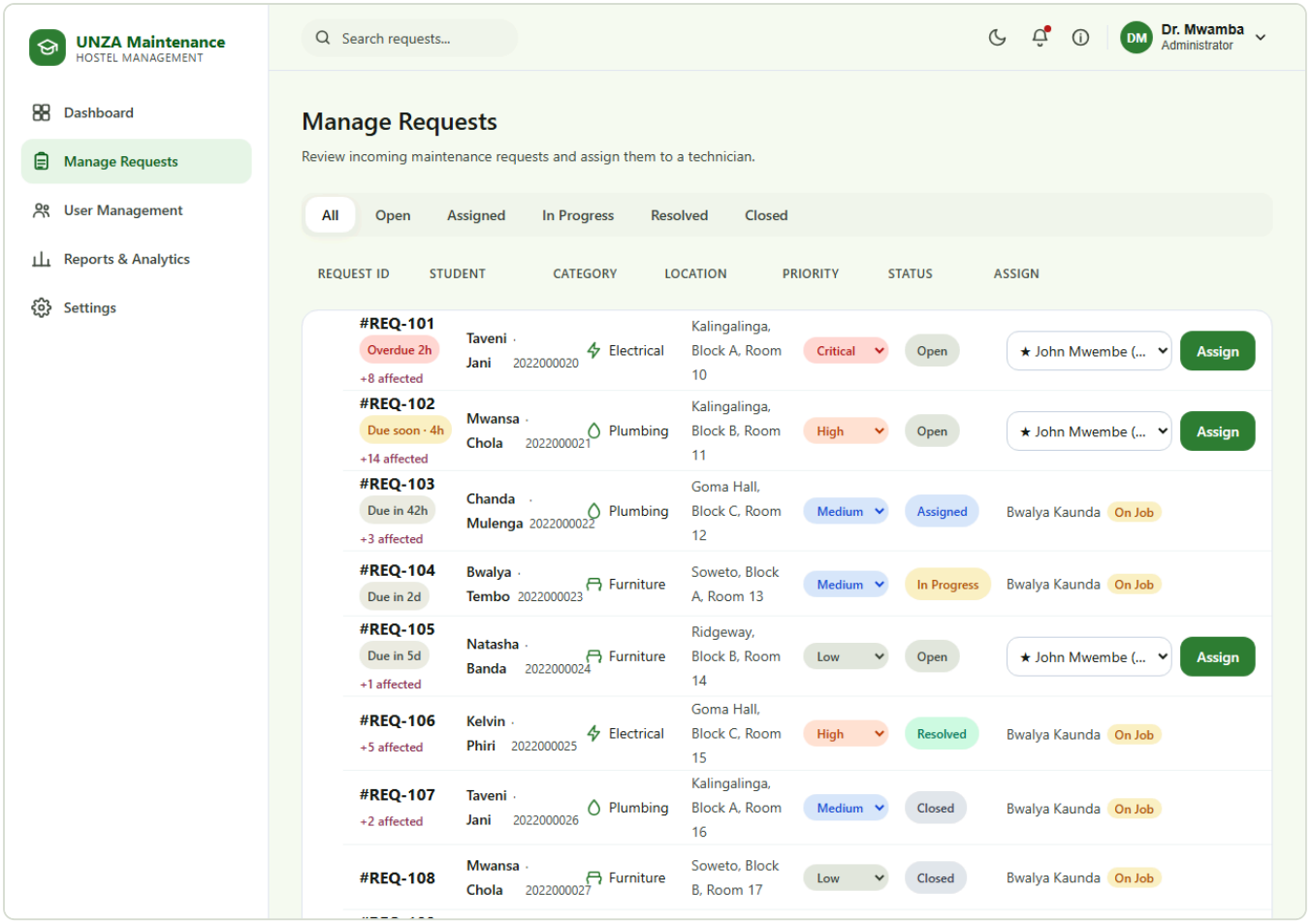
Open **Manage Requests**. Use the **Overdue** tab to see, at a glance, every request that has passed its target time — regardless of its status — with a count badge. The dashboard's **Overdue Requests** tile (4.1) opens straight into this tab.



Every request appears with:

What you see	Meaning
Overdue 2h / Due soon · 4h / Due in 2d	The resolution deadline (see section 7)
+8 affected	How many other students used **Me too** on this issue
Priority dropdown	Change urgency at any time
Assign column	Choose a technician and press **Assign**

To assign: open the technician dropdown, choose someone and press **Assign**. The system marks a ★ **recommended** technician — the one who is available and has the fewest active jobs — and pre-selects them, so assigning is usually one tap. Each entry shows workload, e.g. ★ *John Mwembe (1 active)*. People who are *Off Duty* are never recommended.

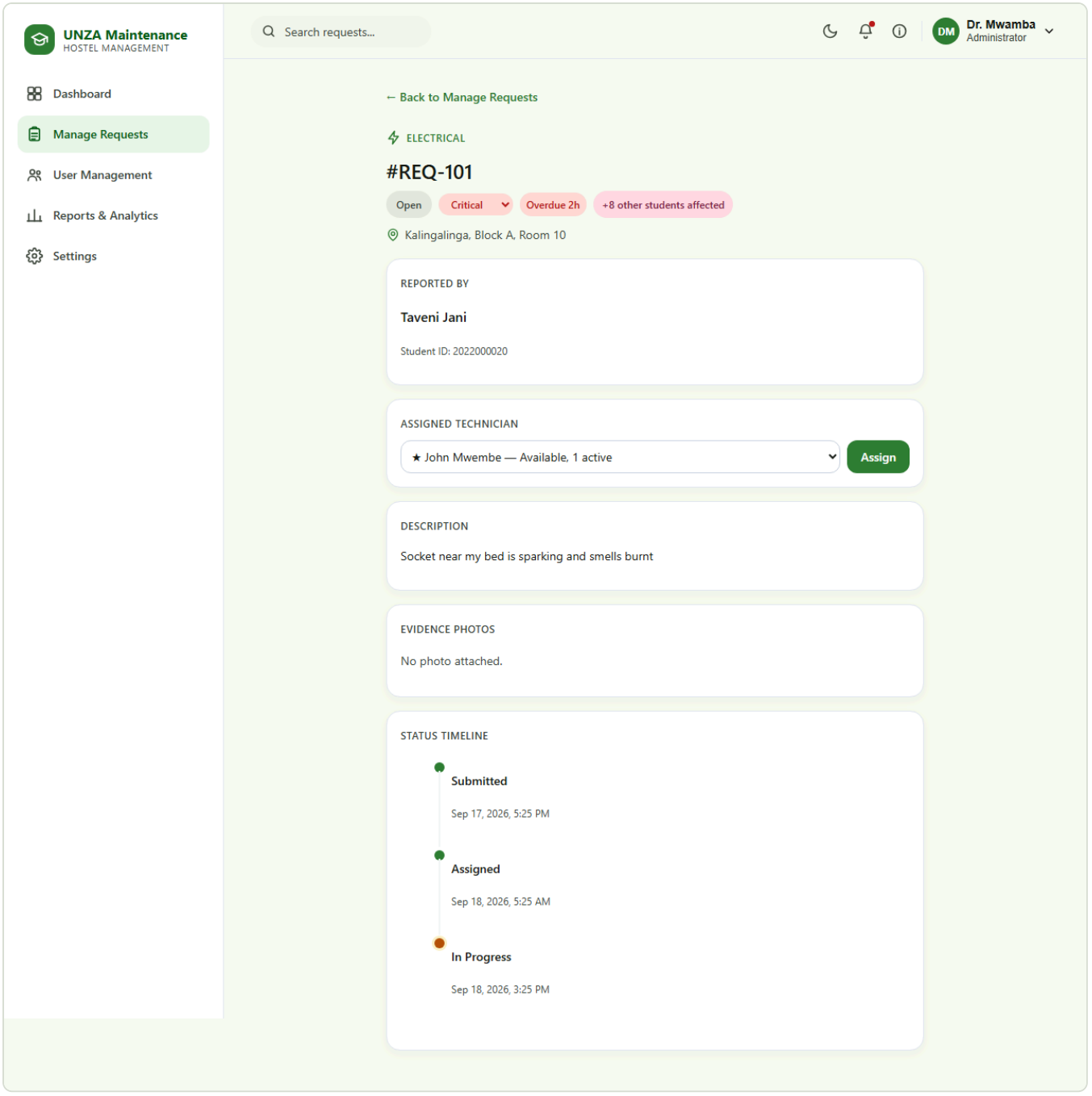


Use the tabs (All, Open, Assigned, In Progress, Resolved, Closed) to filter, or the top search box (by number, description, category, student name or ID).

4.3 A single request

Click a request number to open its page: the reporter, the full description, the photo, a **Comments** box (you, the student and the assigned technician can talk there — see 2.4), the timeline, the technician's **Work Completed** proof and the student's rating. From here you can also:

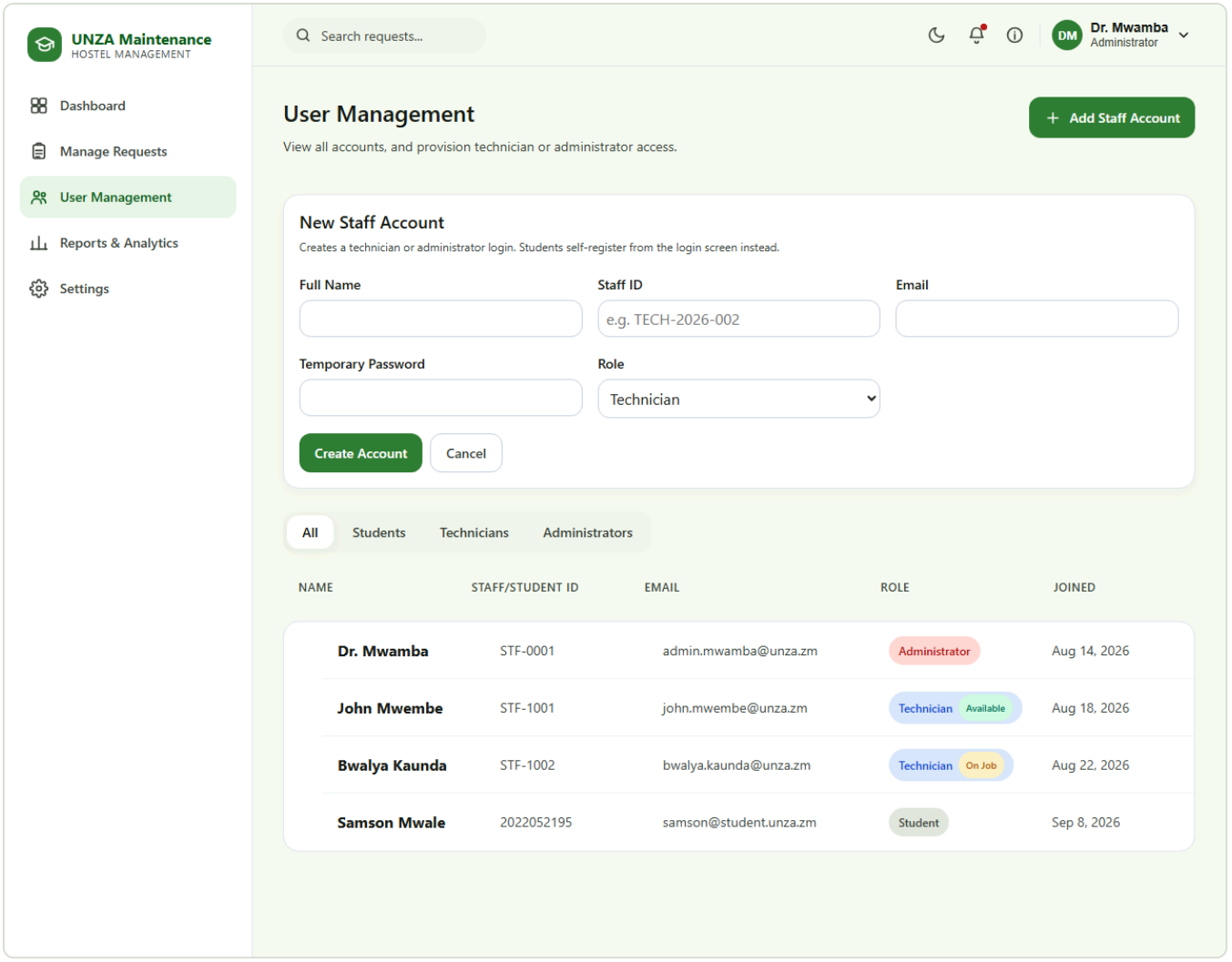
- change **priority**,
- **assign** a technician (open requests),
- **advance the status** (Mark In Progress, Mark as Resolved, Close Ticket).



4.4 Manage staff accounts

Open **User Management** to see every account and filter by role.

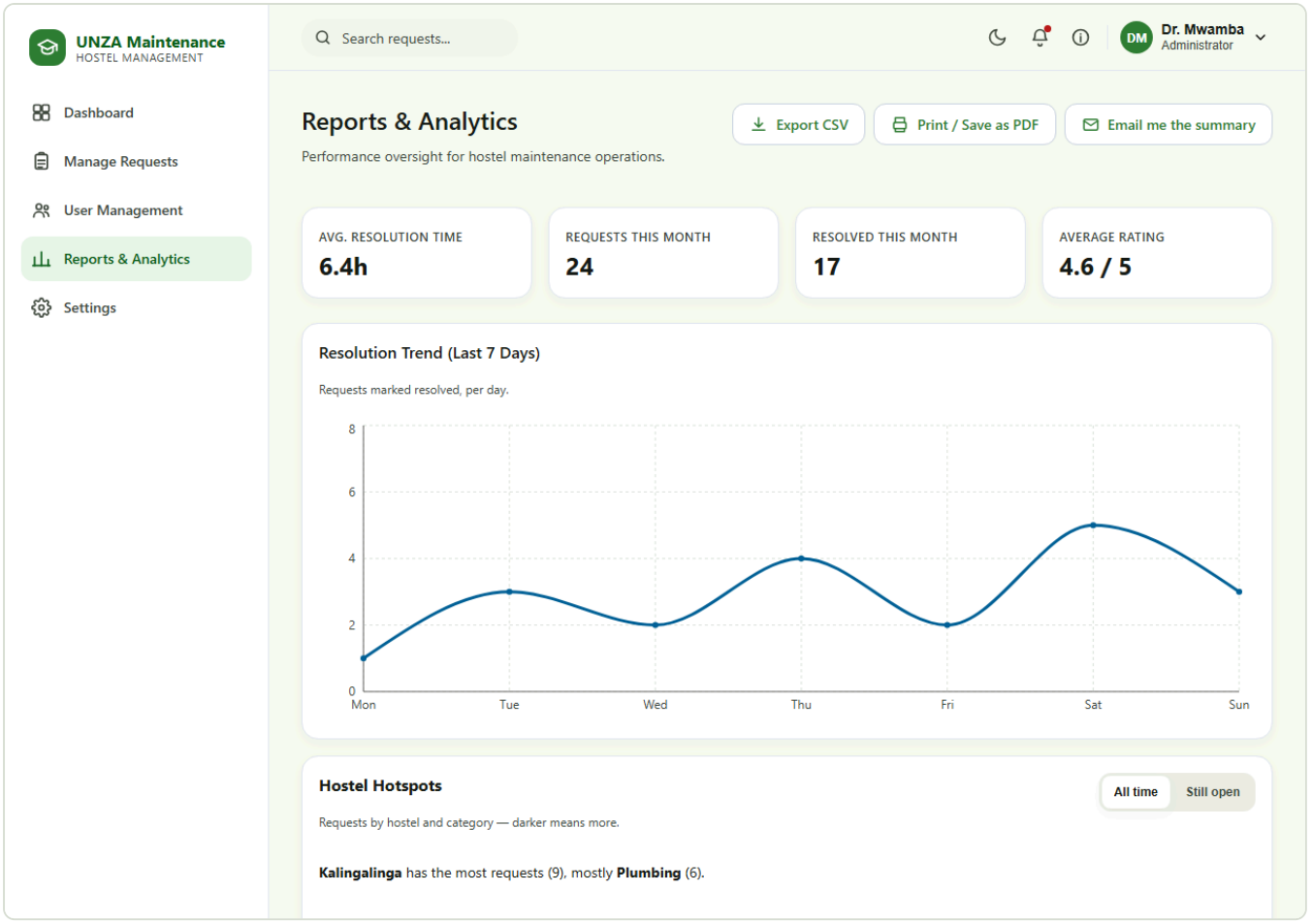
To create a technician or administrator: press **Add Staff Account**, fill in the full name, staff ID, email, a temporary password (at least 8 characters) and the role, then **Create Account**. Give the person their staff ID and temporary password. Students cannot be created here — they register themselves.

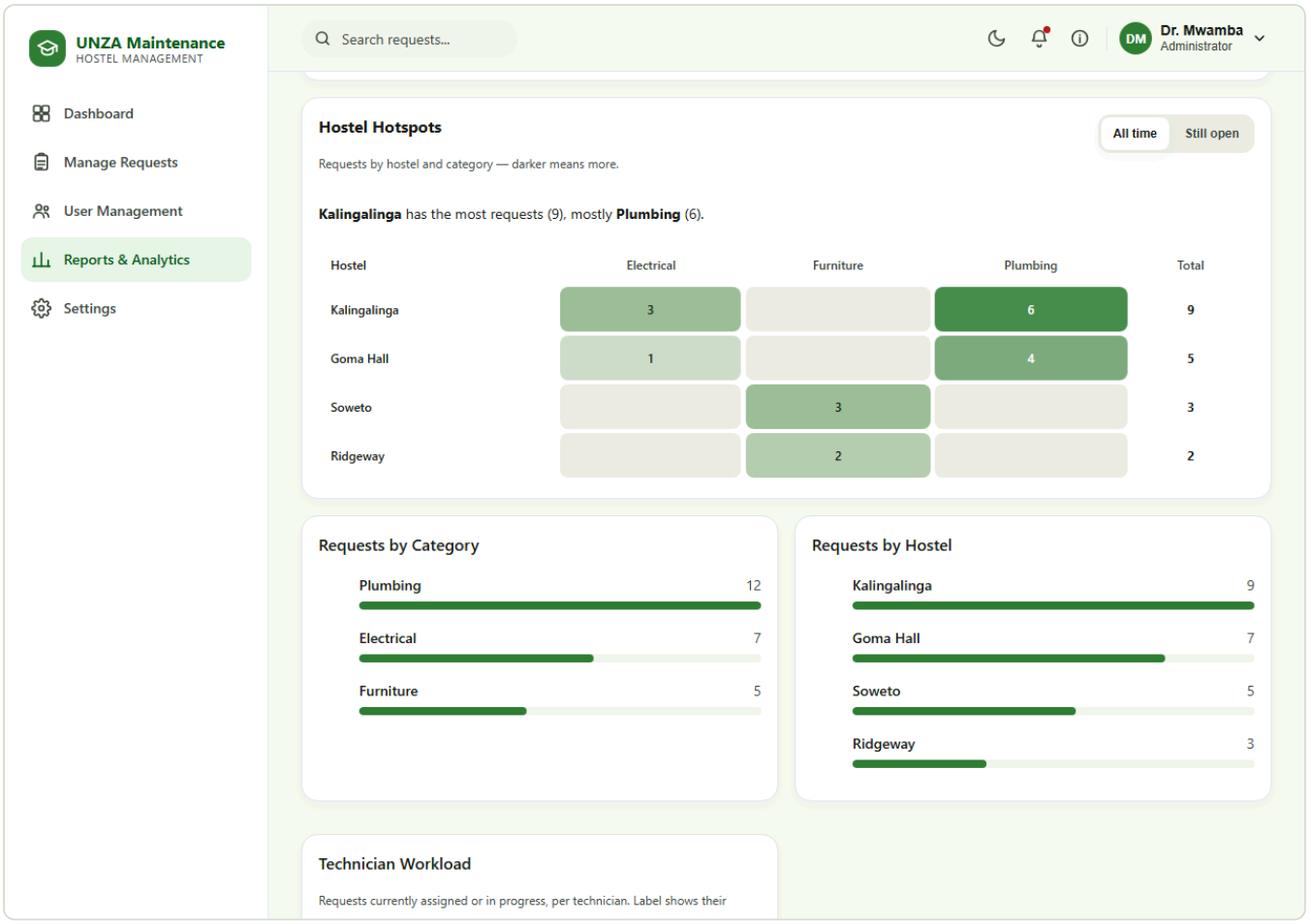


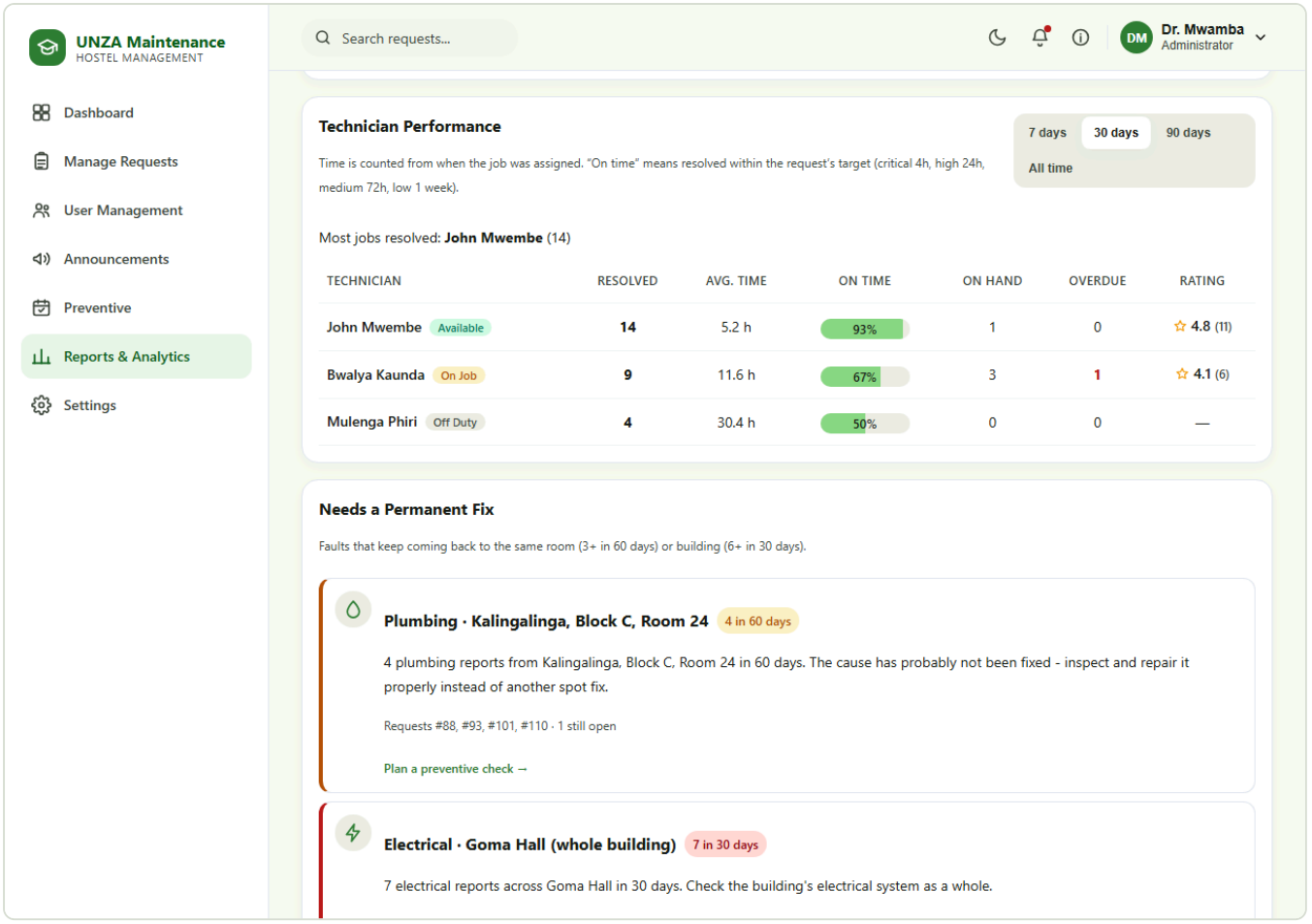
4.5 Reports and analytics

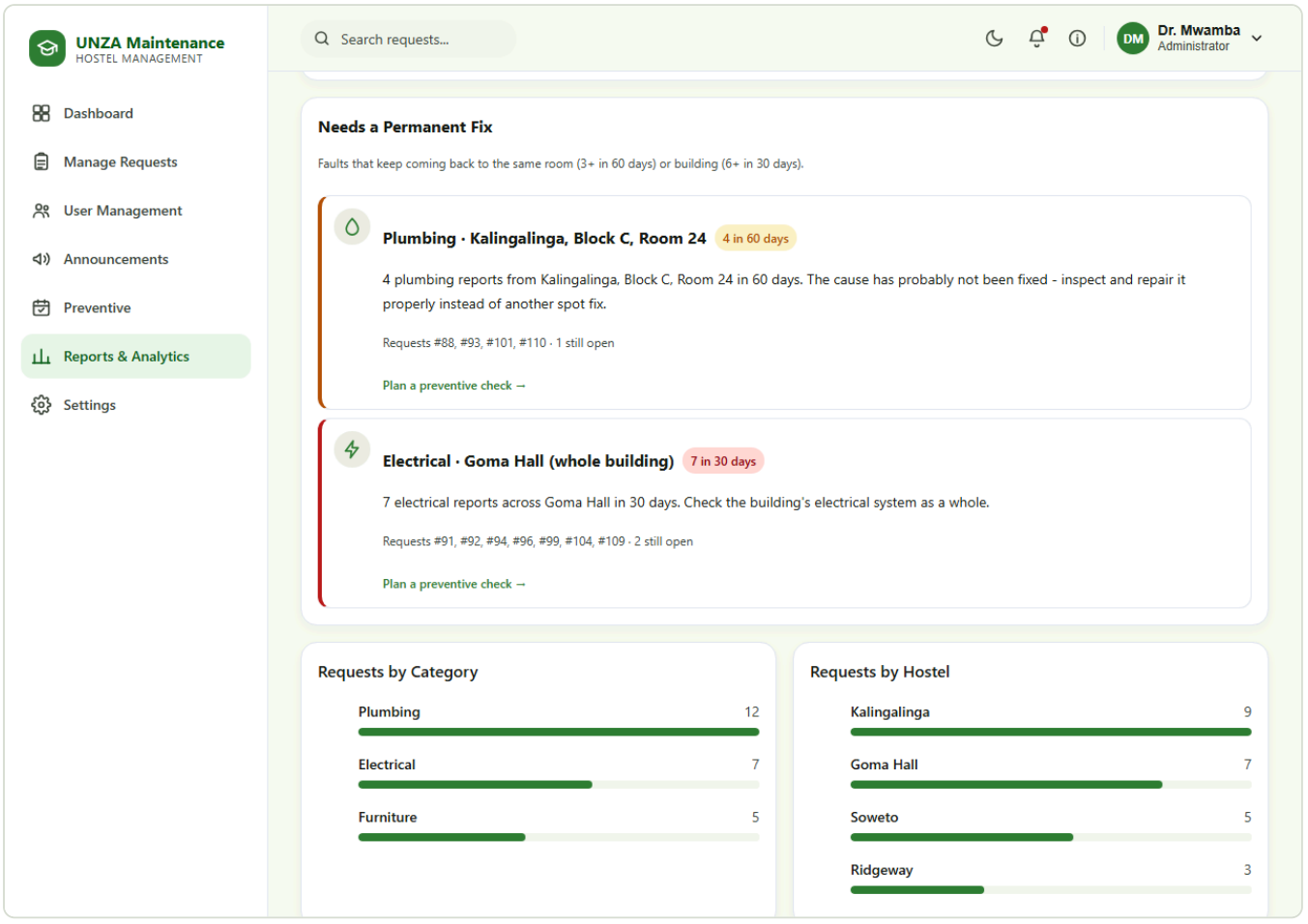
Open **Reports & Analytics**:

- Summary numbers including **Average Rating**.
- **Resolution Trend** for the last 7 days.
- **Hostel Hotspots** — a grid of hostels × categories; **darker = more requests**. The sentence above it names the busiest hostel. Use **All time / Still open** to switch between history and what needs doing now.
- **Requests by Category**, **Requests by Hostel** and **Technician Workload**.
- **Technician Performance** — a table ranking every technician by jobs resolved, average time, on-time rate, jobs on hand, overdue count and student rating, over a window you choose (7/30/90 days or all time).
- **Needs a Permanent Fix** — faults that keep coming back to the **same room** (3 or more times in 60 days) or across a **whole hostel** (6 or more times in 30 days), with a suggestion and a **"Plan a preventive check"** link (see 4.7).


UNZA Maintenance
HOSTEL MANAGEMENT
Search requests...
Dr. Mwamba
Administrator
Dashboard
Manage Requests
User Management
Reports & Analytics
Settings
Reports & Analytics
Performance oversight for hostel maintenance operations.
Export CSV
Print / Save as PDF
Email me the summary
AVG. RESOLUTION TIME
6.4h
REQUESTS THIS MONTH
24
RESOLVED THIS MONTH
17
AVERAGE RATING
4.6 / 5
Resolution Trend (Last 7 Days)
Requests marked resolved, per day.
8
6
4
2
0
Mon
Tue
Wed
Thu
Fri
Sat
Sun
Hostel Hotspots
All time
Still open
Requests by hostel and category — darker means more.
Kalingalinga has the most requests (9), mostly Plumbing (6).


UNZA Maintenance
HOSTEL MANAGEMENT
Search requests...
Dr. Mwamba
Administrator
Dashboard
Manage Requests
User Management
Reports & Analytics
Settings
Hostel Hotspots
All time
Still open
Requests by hostel and category — darker means more.
Kalingalinga has the most requests (9), mostly Plumbing (6).
Hostel
Electrical
Furniture
Plumbing
Total
Kalingalinga
3
6
9
Goma Hall
1
4
5
Soweto
3
3
Ridgeway
2
2
Requests by Category
Plumbing 12
Electrical 7
Furniture 5
Requests by Hostel
Kalingalinga 9
Goma Hall 7
Soweto 5
Ridgeway 3
Technician Workload
Requests currently assigned or in progress, per technician. Label shows their





Export and share

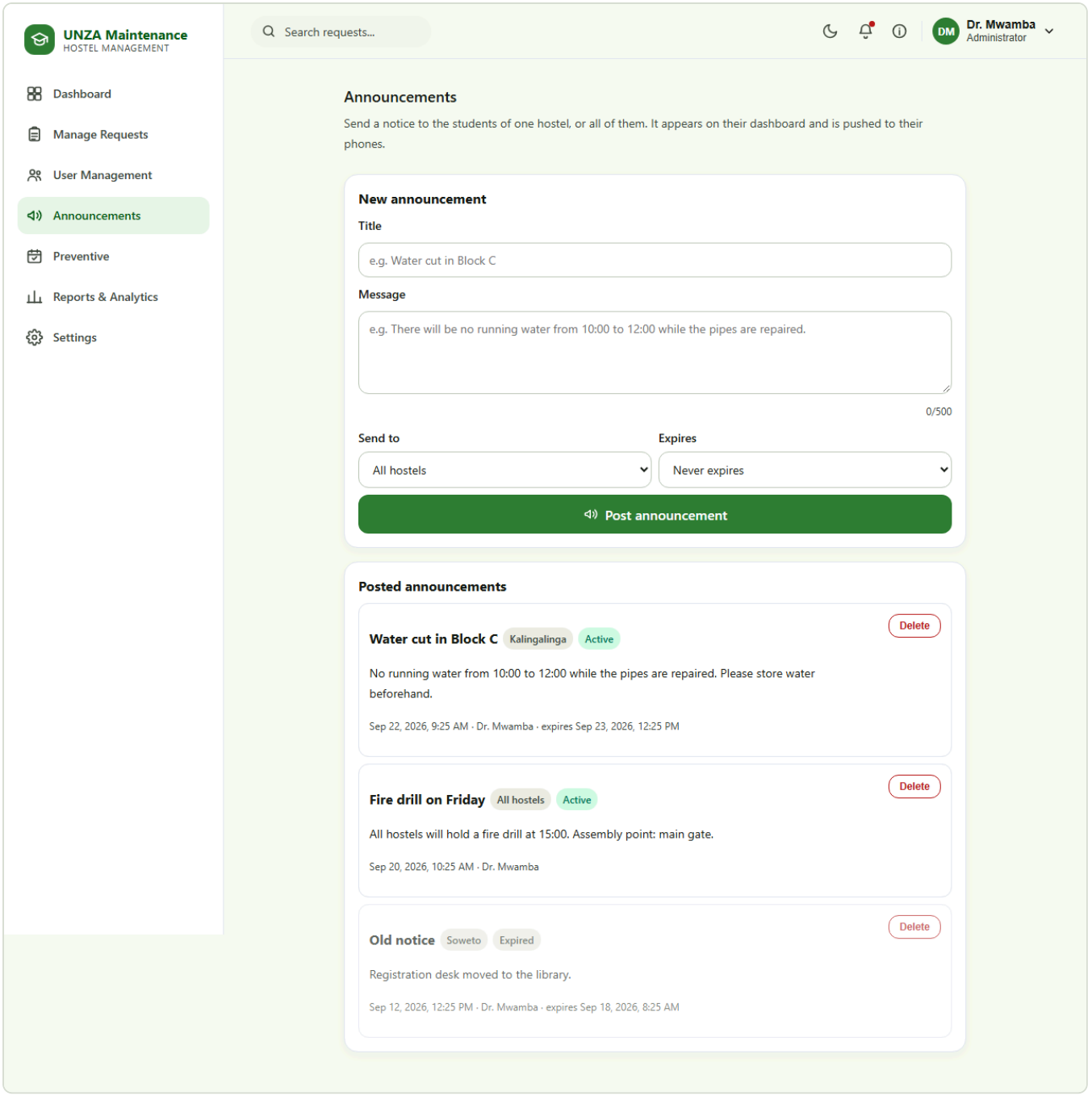
- **Export CSV** — downloads every request as a spreadsheet.
- **Print / Save as PDF** — produces a clean printable report.
- **Email me the summary** — sends the weekly summary to your own email address straight away.

4.6 Send an announcement

Open **Announcements** to notify students. This is for hostel-wide notices — a water cut, a fire drill, anything everyone in a building (or everyone, full stop) needs to know.

1. Write a **Title** and a **Message**.
2. Choose **Send to** — one hostel, or **All hostels**.
3. Choose when it **Expires** (or leave it to never expire).
4. Press **Post announcement**.

Students in the audience see it as a banner on their dashboard (2.1a) and get a push notification. The list below the form shows every announcement you have posted, whether it is still **Active** or has **Expired**, and lets you **Delete** one early.



4.7 Preventive maintenance

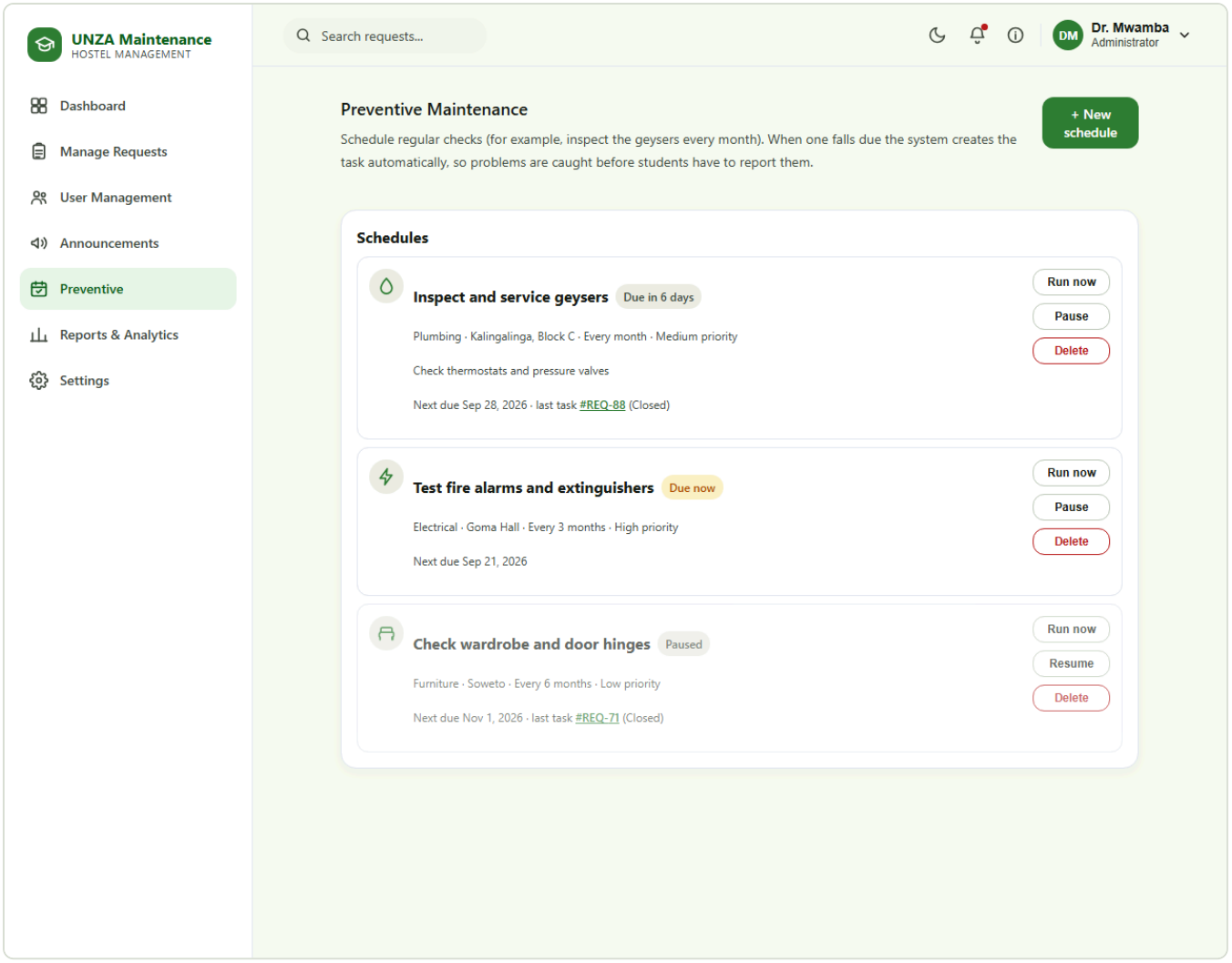
Open **Preventive** to schedule recurring checks — inspecting the geysers every month, testing fire extinguishers every quarter — so problems are caught before a student has to report them.

1. Press **+ New schedule**.
2. Fill in **what needs doing**, the **category**, **hostel** (and, optionally, a specific room/area), **how often**, the **priority** of the task it creates, and when the **first task is due**.
3. Press **Create schedule**.

When a schedule falls due, the system creates a normal maintenance request for it automatically — it goes through assignment, technician work and proof of work exactly like a student-reported request, just labelled "*Preventive maintenance: …*". A new task is **not** created while the previous one for that schedule is still open, so tasks never pile up.

For each schedule you can:

- **Run now** — create its task immediately, without waiting for it to fall due.
- **Pause** / **Resume** — Resuming moves the next due date into the future, so it does not fire instantly for an old date.
- **Delete** — removes the schedule; tasks it already created are kept.



> **Tip:** on the **Needs a Permanent Fix** card (4.5), press **Plan a preventive check** to jump here with the hostel, room and category already filled in.

4.8 Automatic alerts and emails

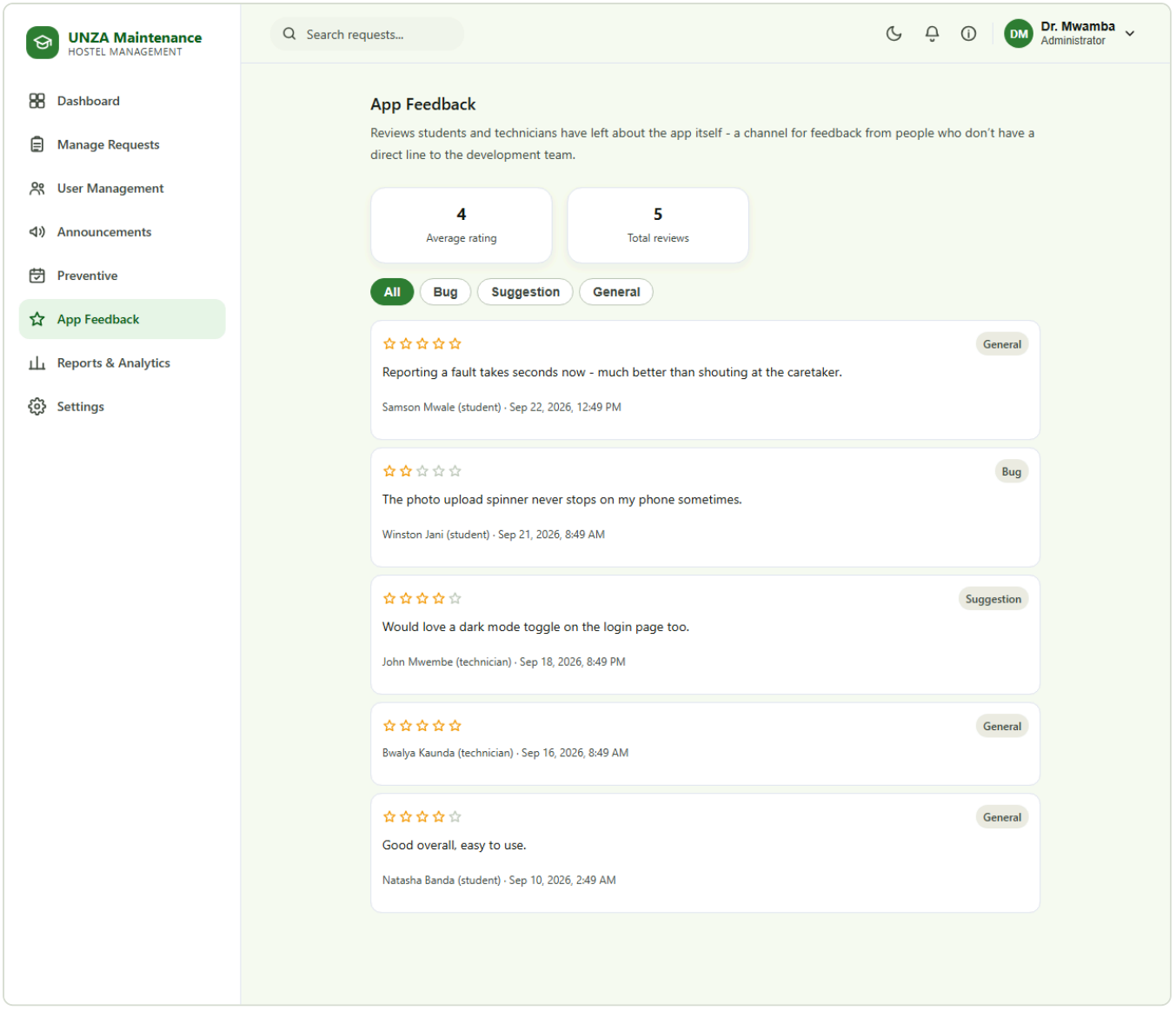
You do not need to do anything for these:

- **Overdue alerts** — the system checks every hour for requests that have passed their deadline and notifies all administrators and the assigned technician. If a request stays overdue you get a **reminder**: every **4 hours** for Critical and High requests, and **once a day** for Medium and Low. Reminders stop as soon as the request is Resolved.
- **New request and status alerts** — push notifications (if you turned them on).
- **Weekly summary email** — every Monday at 08:00 (Lusaka time) to all administrators.

- **Preventive maintenance tasks** — created automatically when a schedule (4.7) falls due.

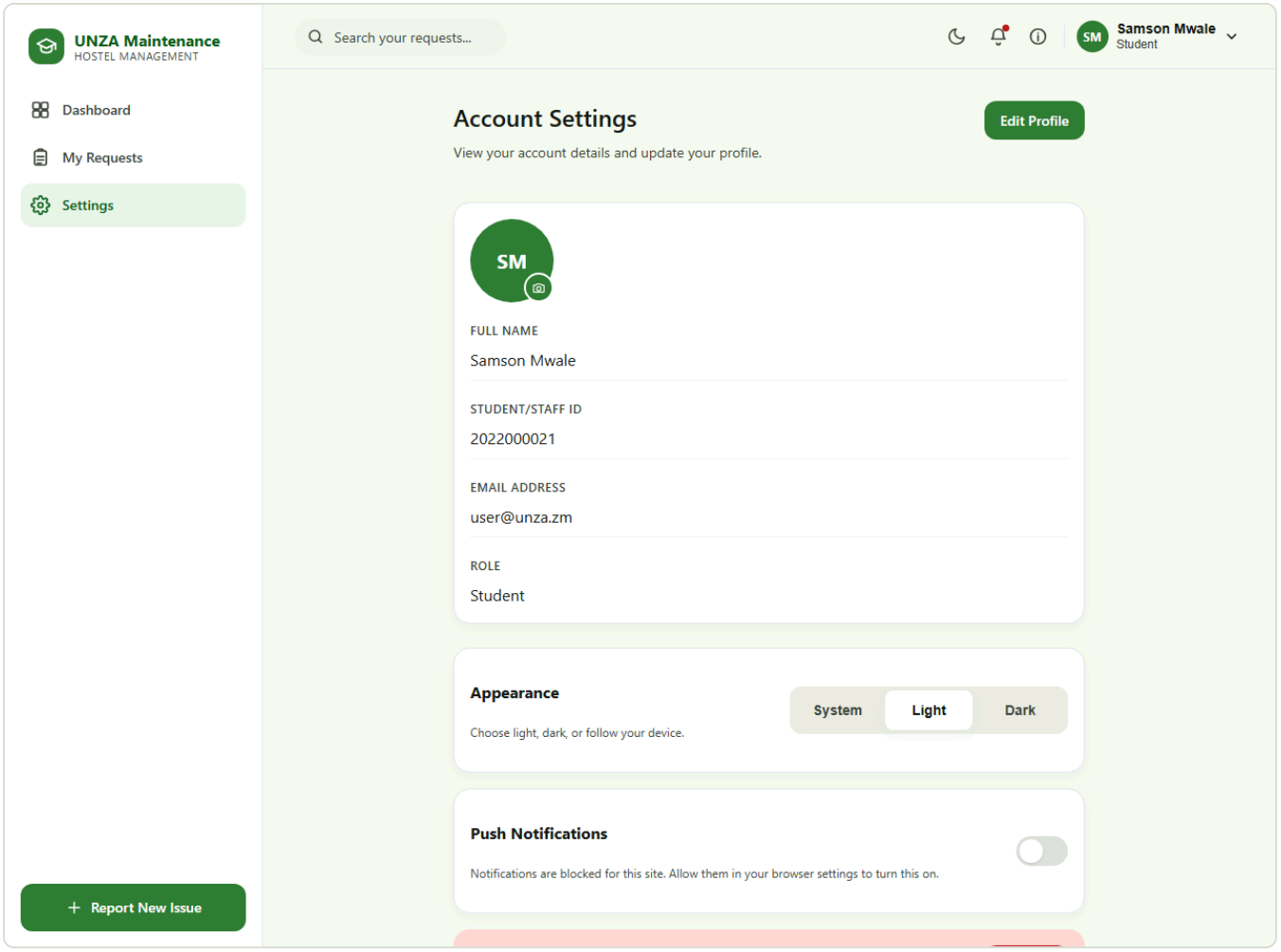
4.9 App Feedback

Students and technicians can send a star rating and a comment about the app itself at any time (see 2.6 / 3.5) — not tied to any particular request. Open **App Feedback** to read what has come in: the **average rating** and **total reviews** at the top, then every submission with who sent it, filterable by category (**Bug**, **Suggestion**, **General**). You also get a push notification the moment a new one arrives. This is the channel for feedback from people who don't otherwise have a direct line to the development team.

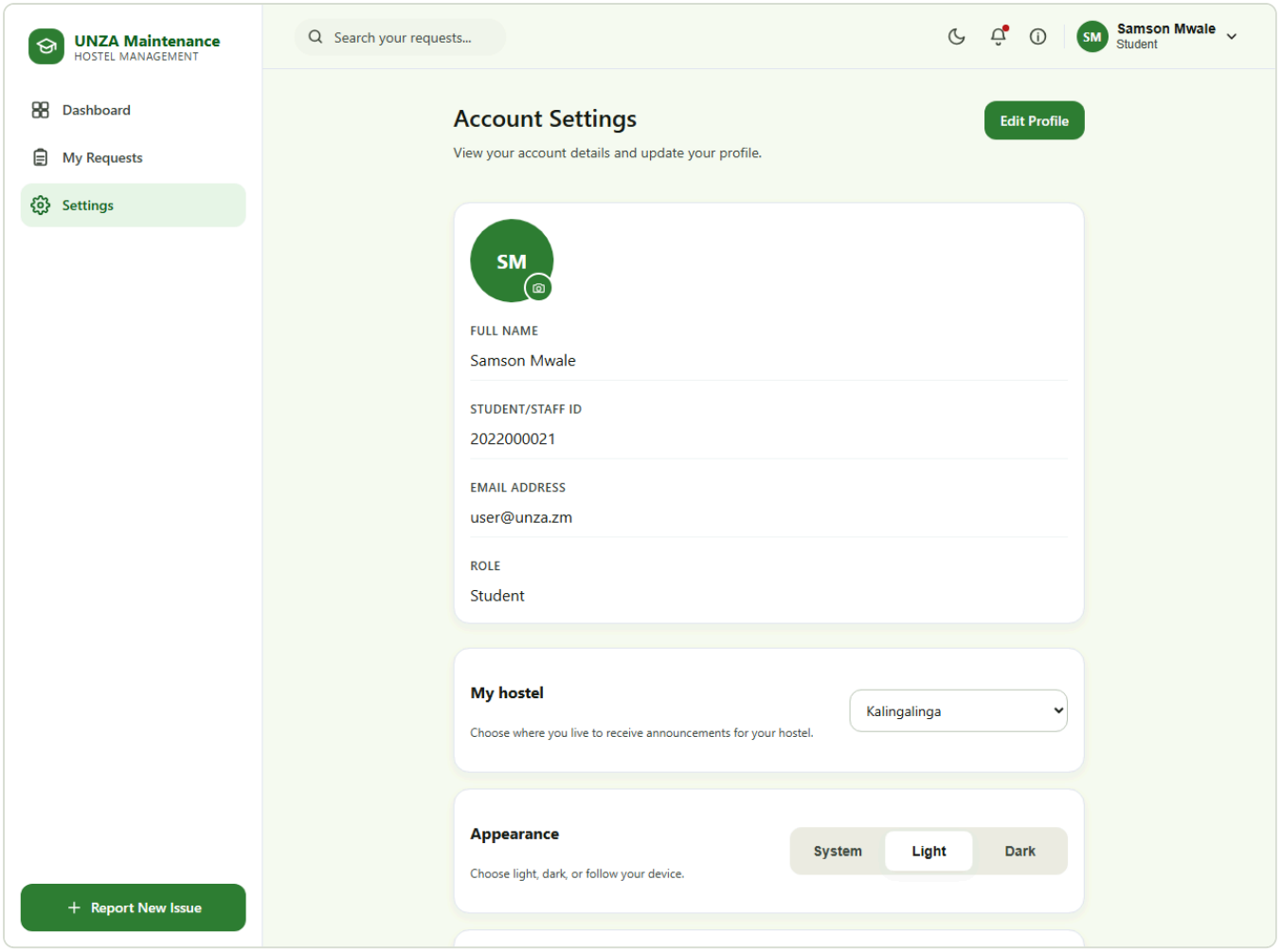


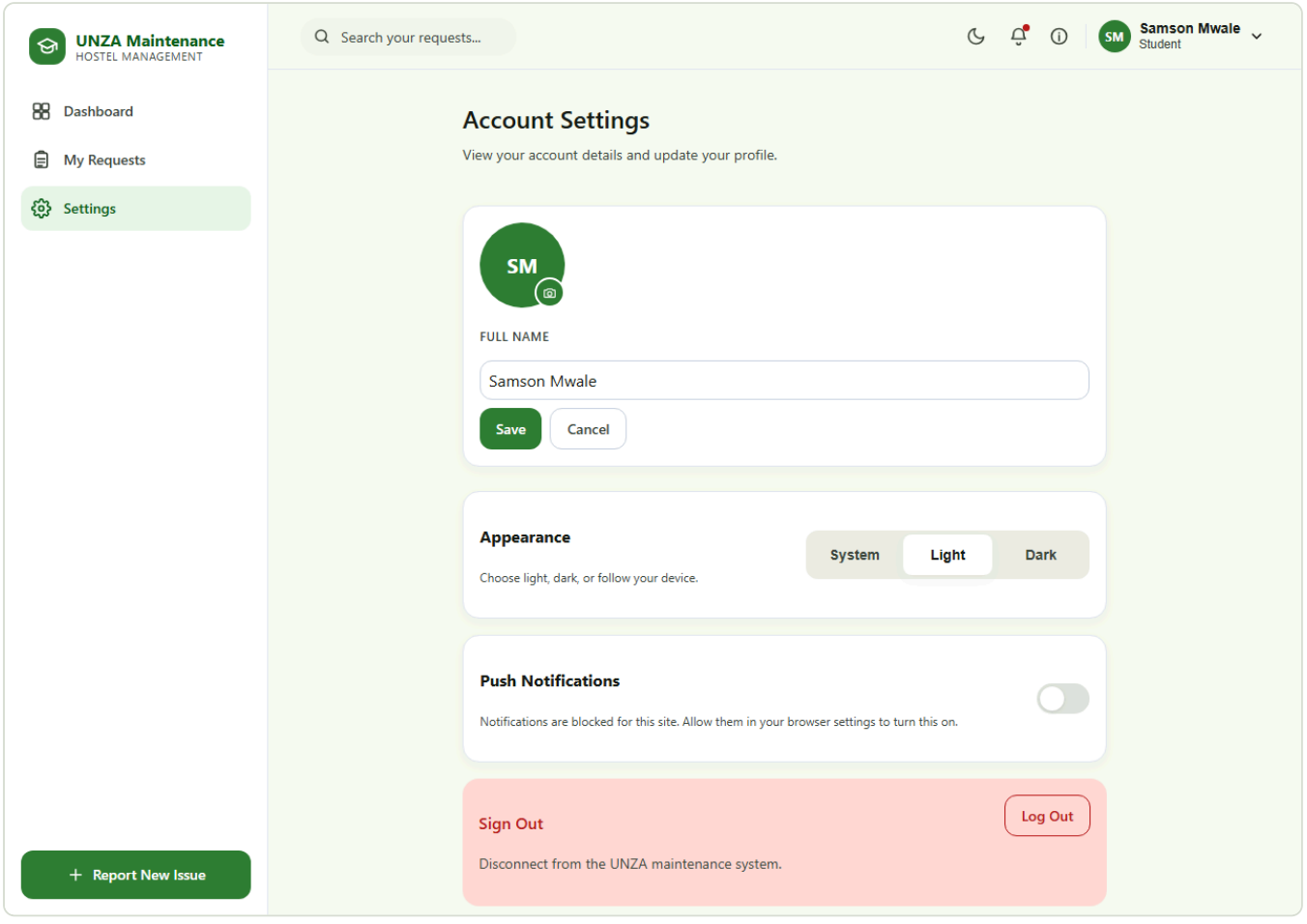
5. Settings, notifications and dark mode

Open **Settings** in the menu.

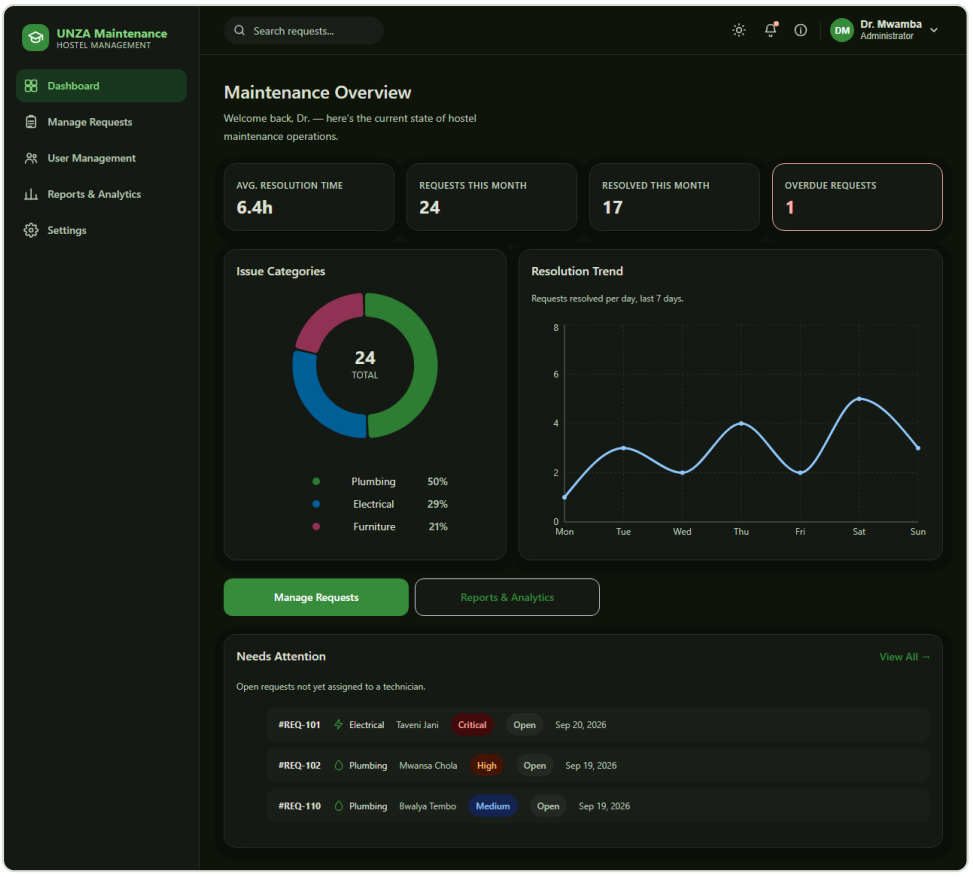
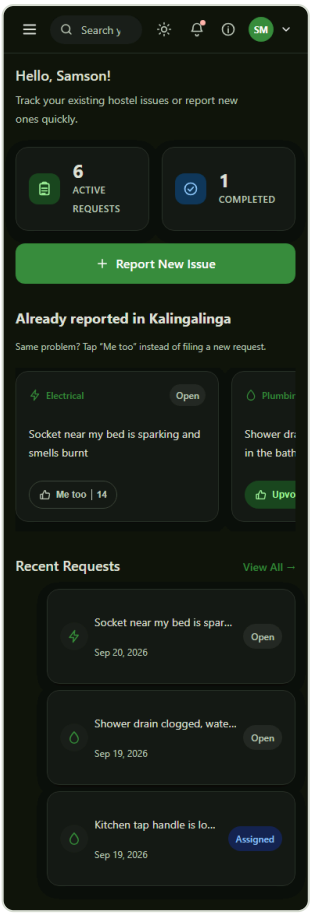


- **Profile** — change your **name** or **photo** (**Edit Profile**, or tap the camera on your picture). Your ID, email and role cannot be changed here.
- **My hostel** *(students only)* — choose where you live so you receive announcements for your hostel (4.6) and your "Already reported" feed defaults to the right place.
- **Appearance** — choose **System** (follows your device), **Light** or **Dark**. The 🌙 button in the top bar switches quickly.
- **Push Notifications** — turn on alerts on *this device*, even when the app is closed. You are asked for permission once. If you previously pressed "Block", allow notifications for the site in your browser settings first.
- **Sign Out** — sign out safely. This also stops notifications on that device, so nobody else using the phone receives yours.


UNZA Maintenance
HOSTEL MANAGEMENT
Search your requests...
Samson Mwale
Student
Dashboard
My Requests
Settings
Account Settings
View your account details and update your profile.
Edit Profile
SM
FULL NAME
Samson Mwale
STUDENT/STAFF ID
2022000021
EMAIL ADDRESS
user@unza.zm
ROLE
Student
My hostel
Choose where you live to receive announcements for your hostel.
Kalingalinga
Appearance
Choose light, dark, or follow your device.
System
Light
Dark
Report New Issue


UNZA Maintenance
HOSTEL MANAGEMENT
Search your requests...
Samson Mwale
Student
Dashboard
My Requests
Settings
Account Settings
View your account details and update your profile.
SM
FULL NAME
Samson Mwale
Save
Cancel
Appearance
Choose light, dark, or follow your device.
System
Light
Dark
Push Notifications
Notifications are blocked for this site. Allow them in your browser settings to turn this on.
Sign Out
Log Out
Disconnect from the UNZA maintenance system.
Report New Issue

Dark mode

Admin (computer)	Student (phone)
	

Who gets which notifications

You are	You are notified when
Student	your request is assigned, or its status changes
Technician	a task is assigned to you, or one of yours becomes overdue
Administrator	a new request is submitted, or a request becomes overdue

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6. Working offline

Hostel Wi-Fi is not always reliable, so the app is built to cope:

- **Pages you have visited** still open quickly, even on a poor connection.
- **Students can write a new request with no connection.** It appears in **My Requests** under *drafts* and is sent automatically when you are back online. You do not need to do anything.
- Other actions (assigning, changing status, rating) need a connection; you will see a message telling you to check your connection if the app can't reach the server — being connected to Wi-Fi does not always mean you have real internet access, so this is worth checking first before assuming something is broken.

- **A brief drop in connection will not sign you out.** If the app can't confirm your session because you're offline for a moment, it keeps you signed in and quietly checks again once your connection returns, instead of sending you back to the login screen.

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7. Meanings of statuses, priorities and badges

Status (the life of a request)

```
Open → Assigned → In Progress → Resolved → Closed
```

Status	Meaning
Open	Submitted, waiting for an administrator to assign a technician
Assigned	A technician has been chosen
In Progress	The technician has started work
Resolved	The repair is finished (you can rate it)
Closed	Fully completed and filed

A request always moves forward one step at a time; it cannot skip or go backwards.

Priority and target time

The clock starts when the request is reported and stops when it is Resolved.

Priority	Use it for	Target
Critical	Danger or serious damage: sparking wires, flooding, burst pipe, gas smell	4 hours
High	Loss of an essential service: no water, no power, door or window that won't lock	24 hours
Medium	A real fault, but not urgent: dripping tap, dead socket	72 hours
Low	Cosmetic or minor: squeaky hinge, scuffed paint	1 week

Deadline badges (staff)

Badge	Meaning
Due in 2d (grey)	Plenty of time left
Due soon · 4h (amber)	Less than a quarter of the time remains
Overdue 2h (red)	The target has passed — needs attention now
(no badge)	Already resolved or closed

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8. Frequently asked questions

I forgot which ID to use. Students use their **student ID**; staff use their **staff ID** (for example `STF-1001`). You can also choose *Log in with email instead*.

Can I edit or cancel a request after submitting it? Not yet. If something changed, contact the maintenance office, or submit a new request with the details.

Why can't I see other students' requests? Your own requests are private. The *Already reported* strip shows only the issue and its status — never who reported it.

Why can't I press "Me too" on some cards? You cannot vote on your own requests, or ones that are already resolved.

Who can see the comments on my request? Only you, the technician assigned to it, and administrators. Nobody else — not even other technicians.

I set my hostel in Settings but I'm not seeing announcements for it. Announcements sent before you set your hostel, or ones that have since expired, will not show. New ones for your hostel will appear from now on.

Why don't I get notifications? Check **Settings** → **Push Notifications** is on for this device, and that notifications are allowed for the site in your browser. On iPhone, add the app to your Home Screen first.

The page didn't update. Pages update by themselves. If you lost your connection for a while, reload the page (or press **Refresh Status** on a request).

I was signed out unexpectedly. Sessions expire for your security, and this can also happen after a very long time offline. A brief drop in connection will not sign you out by itself (see section 6). If it does happen, sign in again and tick **Remember this device** on your own phone.

How is sending feedback different from rating a repair? Rating a repair (2.5) is about one technician's work on one finished job. Sending feedback (2.6) is about the app itself — a bug, a suggestion, or a general impression — and goes straight to the development team, not to any technician.

Who do I contact for help? Press the ⓘ icon for the status guide, or contact your hostel's maintenance administrator.